

Block

4

PARTICIPATORY DEVELOPMENT COMMUNICATION

UNIT 14

Media Literacy

UNIT 15

Right to Information

UNIT 16

Civic Journalism

UNIT 17

Mobile Journalism

UNIT 18

Community Media and Development



UNIT 14 MEDIA LITERACY

Structure

- 14.0 Introduction
- 14.1 Learning Outcomes
- 14.2 Media Literacy: Concept and Definition
 - 14.2.1 Need for Media Literacy
 - 14.2.2 Functions of Media Literacy
- 14.3 Process of Media Literacy
- 14.4 Core Concepts of Media Literacy
 - 14.4.1 Media Messages are constructed
 - 14.4.2 Media Messages are constructed using creative language
 - 14.4.3 Different people experience the same media message differently
 - 14.4.4 Media have embedded values
 - 14.4.5 Messages are organised to gain power
- 14.5 Evaluation of the Credibility of Information
- 14.6 Let Us Sum Up
- 14.7 References and Further Readings
- 14.8 Answer to Check Your Progress Exercises

14.0 INTRODUCTION

We have discussed in the previous unit that the globalised media environment and unlimited avenues for information generation and dissemination have led to most people falling under the category of media audiences and being influenced by it. We begin our interaction with media at a very early age and the relationship strengthens as years go by. New media and messages make an inroad into our everyday existence and leave an imprint on our minds.

McLuhan's famous adage, 'Medium is the message' clearly emphasised the role of the medium in comprehending the message. We come across various media sending forth messages – some complimentary and some contradictory. In such a scenario, it is easy for us to get into the habit of imbibing the messages without comprehending them. We face, what is commonly termed as 'Information overload'.

The information we receive through the vast network of disseminating media; appears to be simple, and easy to understand. It caters to all the areas of interest, entertainment, news, current affairs etc. It comes to us in our spoken language that we recognise both linguistically and cognitively. The reality, however, is that the media uses a complex audio-visual 'language' which has its own grammar. The language of word, pictures, moving pictures and music can be used to express many-layered concepts and ideas about the world. It can also be used to create false ideas and notions as everything may not be obvious at first. The images fly by the mind's eye and stay on in the deep recesses of our mind. If we wish to be able to navigate our lives through this multi-media culture, we need to be fluent in 'reading' and 'writing' the language of images and sounds just as we have always been able to 'read' and 'write' the printed language.

The all encompassing prevalence of media makes it imperative that we learn the language of media and learn how to derive meaning out of all its messages. Just as computer education became necessary to be a part of the literate world, media literacy is now equally important.

14.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this Unit, you should be able to:

- define media literacy;
- describe the process of media literacy;
- outline the core concepts of media literacy;
- evaluate the credibility of information;
- explain the power of visual images; and
- and critically analyse media messages

14.2 MEDIA LITERACY: CONCEPT AND DEFINITION

Media literacy involves learning to access, analyse, evaluate and create media in a variety of forms (Aspen Media Literacy Leadership Institute, 1992). The definition lays stress on creating media messages, which is only one aspect of media literacy. We need to understand media literacy as a wholesome education which is more about helping audiences of different age groups become competent, critical and literate in all media forms so that they are able to make meaning of all that they see or hear, rather than letting the medium control their thinking.

Media literacy empowers you to understand the media, the rationale of media, the reasons for messages, the implication of visual images and the economics of the media industry. You will be capable of not only finding the answers to your questions from the media but also raise pertinent questions when required. Thus, you will not get carried away by the images of real or imaginary world that are put before you by the media.

Media literacy also helps you understand your surroundings. It helps you make more informed decisions, as you are able to see the hidden meanings behind the messages. In brief, media literacy makes you a more discerning user of media outputs.

14.2.1 Need for Media Literacy

The first and most important requirement for a healthy democracy is to have enlightened electorate. Media literacy creates educated electorates, who are able to see through the campaign strategies and are capable of critically evaluating manifestoes and election speeches. The other important reasons for media literacy are:

Influence of media on our daily life: You must have observed that even little toddlers and small children are addicted to mediated communication all day. For some of our children, television acts as a baby sitter and internet as a friend. In such a situation, it is important that children should also be media literate and understand that Tom and Jerry are only cartoons and in real life one can get hurt if one runs like them!

Media shapes our perception of the world: If we watch too much of a certain type of programme, we start to believe that the society is just like that. Media literacy frees us from the stereotypes created by the images projected at us.

Media is urban and elite oriented, but the society is not: In our real lives, we have to work hard for a living and in our films and television serials; life is depicted to be very rosy. A media literate person will not feel frustrated at this situation and will understand that real life is different from what is depicted. Thus, media literacy helps us to see the difference.

Technology changes the look of the world every day: Media products flood the market and change the way people read, talk, write and understand. A media literate person is able to follow the media as per his/her individual requirement and is not led by the diktats of the market.

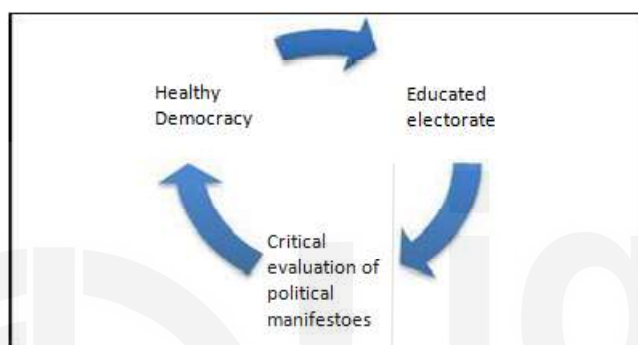


Fig. 14.1 Importance of Media Literacy in Democracy

14.2.2 Functions of Media Literacy

Media literacy as an area of education, must explore the nature and influence of media and media messages in our culture. As far as our culture is concerned, media no longer only influences it; but is already a part of it. From mobile phones, cameras, computers, laptops, internet, newspapers, television to cinema, all the products of media are part of our everyday life and hence our culture. Media literacy therefore helps us understand our culture.

Media literacy does not intend to create critiques of media systems or the society who are forever looking for political agendas, stereotypes or misrepresentations; it however, does intend to create a media consumer who is capable of taking wise decisions and is not unintentionally influenced by media.

Media literacy does not function as a means to criticise the media and find faults with all the messages as it would amount to taking a very narrow dimension to this vast field. However, it involves critically analysing the media only when you have thoroughly understood the meaning behind the messages.

Although some experts believe that media literacy is the knowledge of media production - it is not. Creating media products is a very specialised aspect of media literacy which actually begins from understanding media messages and systems.

Media literacy aims to help you look at the media experience from multiple perspectives, which would include your own educated opinion about media messages. Media literacy does NOT tell you to not interact with the media. It only teaches you to interact carefully, think critically and understand intelligently.

14.3 PROCESS OF MEDIA LITERACY

In order to understand the process of media literacy it will be useful to revisit the famous Model of Communication Process given by the political scientist Harold Lasswell (1948) who defined an act of communication in terms of the following questions:

- Who (Communicator)
- Says What (Message)
- In Which Channel (Medium)
- To Whom (Receiver)
- With what effect? (Effect)

According to Lasswell there are three functions for communication:

1. Surveillance of the environment;
2. Correlation of the parts of society in responding to the environment; and
3. Transmission of social heritage from one generation to next.

Lasswell model suggests that a media message flows in a multicultural society with multiple audiences through various channels. Understanding media is also about understanding different players in the system of mediated communication. Each of the entities outlined by Lasswell can be understood in terms of media, messages and audiences.

‘Who’ or the Communicator is the savvy individual or media organisation who can use the media systems to send forth their messages.

‘What’ is the message that is being sent forth by the medium - it is influenced by many factors and may not be error free.

Channel refers to the medium being used. Each medium has its own characteristics and the nature of the message changes.

‘To Whom’ refers to the consumers of media products and

‘With what effect’ implies the repercussion of the message.

The process is not as simple as it appears; so let us understand it in the context of Media Literacy. The process of Media Literacy begins with the audience - the consumers of media products. When we become media literate, we start to collect relevant and useful information and comprehend its meaning effectively. We gather and interpret information, appreciate the good and the bad, and become media savvy. Given below are the ways in which this process is carried out:

- Each message is understood independently and in relationship with others. The message may come from any media. This is understood as ‘deconstruction of message’.
- After deconstruction the messages are analysed in their context and presentation - this is called ‘decoding’.
- Messages are now ‘read’ in the real sense.

The above process will also help you to look at the messages coming from the media with a new perspective.

- Biases and prejudices can be recognized and treated likewise; We can read between the lines;
- The intent of the sender becomes clear;
- The media and media channels are understood from the messages they send forth and also how they do it;
- We understand the ideology of a media organisation that brings out these messages; and
- We understand our society better.

The fact that you have learnt how to ‘read’ the media messages will also help you to ‘write’ in a better format. You will be able to organize your thoughts, draft your text, add images and/or sounds, edit, and present the final message.

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1) Explain the term Media Literacy.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) Why do we need to become media literates?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

3) Describe the process of Media Literacy.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

14.4 CORE CONCEPTS OF MEDIA LITERACY

The core concept of media literacy challenges the premise of mere consumption of media messages. It postulates that if we do not ask questions about media messages and media products we will not be able to distinguish between beneficial and harmful messages. In our language classes, we are taught to differentiate between a poetry, essay, letter, note, memo, and article. Does a common newspaper reader know the difference between a news story and a feature article or main news and paid news? If we knew the difference we would know which is factual and which contains elements of storytelling.

According to the Centre for Media Literacy (2003), the five core concepts of media literacy are:

1. All media messages are ‘constructed’;
2. Media messages are constructed using a creative language with its own rules;
3. Different people experience the same media message differently;
4. Media have embedded values and points of view; and
5. Most media messages are organised to gain power. Let us understand this through a diagram



Fig 14.2 Core Concepts

Business decisions	:	Profit making, Market acceptability, Image enhancement
Message	:	Based on stereotypes, crossing several barriers
Audience	:	Accept or reject message as per their knowledge and interest levels
Production	:	Visuals, sound, dialogues and other imagery used to create a perfect, believable message for the audience.

We will try to understand each concept one by one.

14.4.1 Media Messages are ‘Constructed’

Whenever we receive any message from any of our media, we need to realize the fact that the message has been designed by somebody for us. We tend to believe that the news being shown is the most important event of the day and that is why it is on television. Let us look at the same situation in another way.

The world is full of people, all of them are engaged in doing something in their lives but only some actions of some people become news. Some actions are told to the rest of the world because some people in some organisations think that the

action was important. Are you able to understand where this whole series of thought is leading? This means that ‘news’ is different from the ‘event’. An event has to be worthy of becoming news and for this it goes through a process of news selection and gathering by a news organisation. It should therefore have specific qualities to qualify as news. Once it qualifies, the reporter narrates the event in his/her words to the audience. Thus by the time, an event becomes news, it has gone through a lot of additions and subtractions.

Let us further understand this with a diagram:

A limited number of events from all the events in the world

Selected by reporters on the basis of news values

Written inverted pyramid giving clear priorities Elements of interest added to it, such as photos, tables, graphs, line drawing, etc. in newspapers and audio visual clips, peoples bytes on TV. This is done on the basis of availability and understanding of the reporter

Appears as a news story in our media

Audience/readers believes it as the most important event of the day

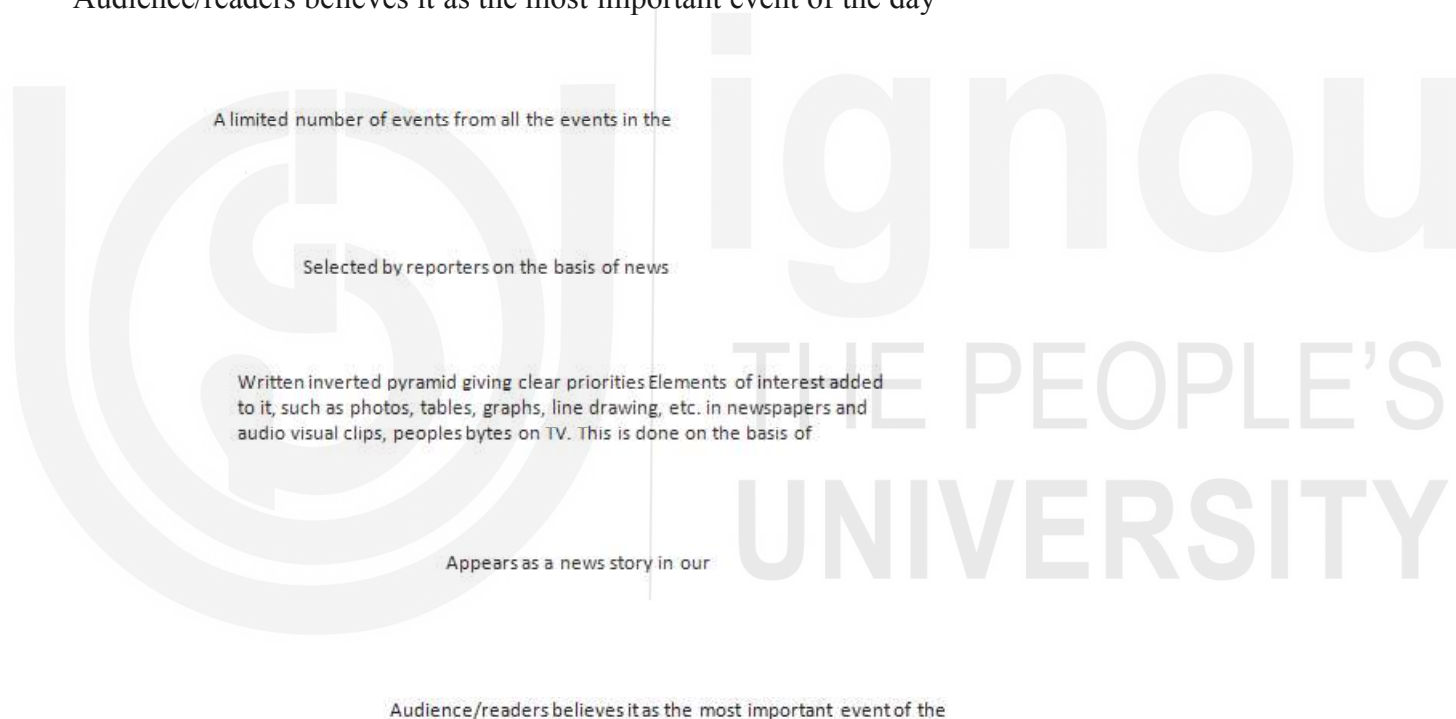


Figure 14. 3 News is a ‘constructed’ narrative

From this diagram it is clear that news is a narrative prepared by the media persons for the audience. We do not get to know about the events that were rejected. If this can happen to the most factual section of our media messages, imagine how much ‘construction’ goes into preparing fiction? Will you be able to consume media messages with an understanding that ‘All media messages are ‘constructed’?

14.4.2 Media Messages are Constructed Using Creative Language

Each of these media messages are a combination of many elements. These elements have their own way of saying things and no message is narrated in

isolation. Let us try to understand with the help of the same example that we used to illustrate the first point.

A news story on television is a narrative of the events as we have already seen. This comes to us along with the use of multimedia elements. These elements are moving pictures (video) and sound (audio). If the news is about a train accident, the camera hovers over the crying face of a victim, it takes a close up of tear filled eyes, a mother carrying a crying child on her shoulders, dead bodies visible at a distance, the reporter comes and goes but the camera relays the pictures of grief.

The camera acts as our eye - it decides what we should see. The cameraperson's judgment at the site of the accident gives shape to the enormity of damage and anguish. We see the world through the eye of the camera. In addition to the video is the audio. The sound adds its own pathos to the scene. Sorrowful music is played to make the scene come alive, but in real life no music is played when we are sad. The music in messages gives us the cue to laugh or cry and the medium tells us that this is a sad story and you should feel bad. The surprising aspect is that we start to feel just as the media tells us to. This means that we get caught in the mood created by the medium and start understanding the world from its point of view. If we could understand the language of the medium we would not be so naïve and yet be able to appreciate the message.

14.4.3 Different People Experience the Same Media Message Differently

Do all of us understand the messages sent out by the media in the same manner or do different people react differently? The reality is that each individual understands the media messages on the basis of his/her own uniqueness. When we understand media messages, we see them through the prism of perception. Our level of interest, previous knowledge, stereotypes in our heads, values and culture all play a part in understanding the message. The message therefore is not just constructed by the sender but is also reconstructed by the receiver.

14.4.4 Media have Embedded Values

We have seen that media messages are parts of reality constructed by media persons, but are the messages totally free of bias? Let us try to understand the process of news creation before it is served to us.

The news gathering process involves

- The reporter gets a list of events.
- S/he decides to attend one.
- S/he reaches the venue and searches out the person from whom s/he can get to know more about the event.
- S/he talks to few persons about the event.
- S/he takes note of the ongoing activity and returns to office. S/he writes the story.
- That is why, it is important to understand that media are always viewpoint oriented even when they are trying to be objective.

14.4.5 Messages are Organised to Gain Power

In the previous units we have discussed at length that media is a big business. In fact, it is a sector of economy and big media houses control everything that goes into the media. A business person would go into the business of media to gain in terms of finances and power. If a media house gets the audience to tune into its programmes day after day, it can sell space/time to the advertisers at a good rate and make profit. The media house can also tailor messages to suit a certain political ideology, philosophy, lifestyle or image. This way, in a democratic country mass media messages can be used to tilt the power equation towards the highest bidder.

A well-informed user of media will apply discretion and power of judgment while exposing him/herself and dear ones to these messages. S/he will critically evaluate the messages while watching or listening to them and gauge their credibility. The best way to analyse media messages is through the use of the Media Triangle, which focuses on Text, Production and Audience.

With the help of this framework we will try to understand the questions to ask while analysing a newspaper story or a magazine article.

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

- Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.
2) Compare your answers with those ones given at the end of this Unit.

1. What are the five core concepts of media literacy?
.....
.....
.....
.....
.....
2. Who decides the content and treatment that is to be given to media messages?
How is this decision making done?
.....
.....
.....
.....
.....
- 2) Who benefits from the message?
.....
.....
.....
.....
.....

14.5 EVALUATION OF THE CREDIBILITY OF INFORMATION

Having understood the market dynamics of mass media let us try to evaluate media messages coming from different sources. The process of evaluation would comprise understanding the background of the message, the medium used for its dissemination, interpretations arising from it, intentions and purpose.

When we watch a TV programme, we are so engrossed in the story telling technique and the powerful narrative created by the visuals and the audio that we do not care much about the deeper meaning that might have been intentionally or unintentionally being formed in our minds. This deeper meaning will eventually rest in our memory bank in the form of stereotypes. In our effort at media literacy, we should stop and check. Let us together analyse a popular film Sholay which most of us have seen at some point of time.

- Notice the characters. How are they dressed? Do they tell you anything from their clothes? The colours chosen? The way they speak? The hairstyle? Are you able to identify a definite effort that has gone into creating the characters in order to make them believable?
- Now, turn off the sound and watch the characters again. Do they seem similar to what they were last time? Are they less effective?
- Now, turn off the video and listen to the sound. Are you able to imagine the character from the background score? Are you able to recognise the accents in their voices? Are you able to 'see the film in your mind'?
- Have you been able to see the effort put in by the film maker with the help of so many other people in creating an ambience and atmosphere for you? He has succeeded in making you believe that these are real people leading real lives.

Try this exercise with an advertisement, a news cast, a news story and you will be able to see the layers of meaning. While watching TV or a film it may not be possible to conduct this type of analysis but after some time, it becomes a habit and the mind is able to understand the messages as narratives and not 'real'.

Base rate and Exemplar

Most news stories can be categorized under two categories: Base rate and Exemplar. Base rate comprises of all the information that is verifiable and specific. It could be data, illustrations, sometimes actual percentages and sometimes generalizations such as 'lots', 'many' etc. In contrast, exemplar is episodic information that describes causes, importance and consequences of a problem with an individualistic perspective. These are stories. (Potter, 2004)

Studies have found that audience like to believe the exemplars more than the base rate. When they read the news stories they understand the narrative from their own perspective and relate them to their personal lives.

Example: Exemplar about Accident/Fire News Fire claims City heart hotel

City heart hotel, the oldest building in Shanbag, was reduced to ashes in a fire mishap last night. No loss of life or injury is reported. One of the proprietors Mr. Hari Gupta, 64, made a miraculous escape from his first-floor office by jumping out of a window.

The fire is believed to have started at about 9.00 p.m., when many customers were finishing dinner. It is suspected to have originated in the kitchen on the ground floor. The two storey building with a timbered frontage was engulfed in flames almost immediately. The cause of the fire is not known.

Talking to the press, the Divisional Officer R. Sinha, who commanded the rescue operations, said “The building was already burning fiercely by the time we arrived. It was a pretty desperate situation.” The fire control operation proved to be difficult because of narrow streets and presence of onlookers. The fire department was assisted by the police and auxiliary firemen to clear the street and carry out the fire fighting operation.

City heart hotel in Main market was built in 1825 and was fairly unique in the Shanbag area because of its historic appearance. It had recently been purchased by brothers, Mr. Hari Gupta and Mr. Ravi Gupta. None of them was available for comment.

With the loss of City heart hotel, Shanbag has lost not only its oldest building but also a famous tourist destination.

This is the 5th incident of fire in the city this month. Approximately goods worth Rs. 5 Crores have been lost in this fire.

The facts in the story are divided into Base rate and Exemplars:

Base Rate

- a) Age of proprietor: 64
- b) Time of the start of fire: 9.00 pm
- c) The year of establishing of the hotel: 1825
- d) Place of origin of fire: Kitchen
- e) Number of floors of the building: 2
- f) Type of facade: Timberage frontage
- g) Number of fire incident: 5th
- h) Loss estimate: Rs 5 Crores

Exemplar

- a) Timber frontage is a risky material to use for façade. All owners of houses with timber frontage will be worried
- b) All those who dined in the hotel in the past will remember their experiences
- c) Neighbouring building owners will be worried about the safety of their buildings.
- d) Other hotels will worry about their fire safety measures.

A look at the above data clearly depicts the parts of the news story that will be remembered by the readers. Try this method with some other media messages, films, advertisements, television serials etc. and you will find yourself recalling the exemplars more than the base rate.

14.6 LET US SUM UP

In this Unit you were exposed to look at media messages as a constructed phenomenon purposely created to influence us in many ways. It was explained that since we live in a mediated environment, we need to understand media better and educate ourselves on the methods in which these messages are created and used.

The meaning of media literacy, its need, purpose and process was explained. Media Literacy was defined as education which helps audiences of different age groups become competent, critical and literate in all media forms. The five core concepts of media literacy were examined to help you to evaluate the credibility of information from different sources. The deconstruction of a media message was explained - how emotions are deliberately created for us with a lot of effort by experts. The difference between base rates and exemplars in the media messages was described and how you can create your own messages using a variety of media tools explained.

We hope that the discussion will enable you to navigate through the media messages and access information from a variety of sources. You will be able to analyse and explore how messages are “constructed” in any of the media (print, verbal, visual or multi-media) and evaluate media’s explicit and implicit messages with your own interpretations.

14.7 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

Herman, E., & Chomsky, N. (2002). *Manufacturing Consent: The Political Economy of the Mass Media*.

Potter, W. (2004). *Theory of Media Literacy: A Cognitive Approach*. Thousand Oaks, Ca.: Sage.

Tyner, K. (2000). *Literacy in a digital world: Teaching and Learning in the Age of Information*. Mahwah, N.J.: Erlbaum

14.8 ANSWER TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS EXERCISES

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

1. Media literacy helps audiences of different age groups become competent, critical and literate in all media forms so that they are able to make meaning of all that they see or hear rather than letting the medium control their thinking. Media literacy empowers us to understand the media, the reasons for messages, the economy of media, the implication of visual images.

We are capable of not only finding the answers to our questions but also raise pertinent questions when required. We will not get carried away by the images of real or imaginary world that are put before us by the media. We will not only

be able to distinguish between fact and fiction but also between half truths and lies.

2. There is a need for us to become media literate for the following reasons:
 - a) The first and most important requirement for a healthy democracy is to have enlightened electorate. Media literacy creates educated electorates, who are able to see through the campaign strategies and are capable of critically evaluating manifestoes and election speeches.
 - b) Media literacy reduces the influence of media on our daily life. As even little toddlers and small children are addicted to mediated communication all day, it is important that children should also be media literate and understand that Tom and Jerry are only cartoons and in real life one can get hurt if one runs like them.
 - c) Media literacy helps us understand the world better and free us from the stereotypes created by the images projected at us.
 - d) Media is urban and elite oriented but the society is not. Media literacy for a living and in our films and television serials; life seems to be very rosy. A media literate person will not feel frustrated at this situation and understand that real life is different from what is depicted.
 - e) Technology changes the look of the world every day. Media products flood the market and change the way people read, talk, write and understand. A media literate person is able to follow the media as per one's individual requirement and is not led by the diktats of the market.
3. The process of Media Literacy begins with the audience. We are the consumers of media products. When we become media literate, we start to collect relevant and useful information and comprehend its meaning effectively. This process is carried out in the following manner:
 - Each message is understood independently and in relationship with others. The message may come from any media. This is understood as deconstruction.
 - After deconstruction the messages are analysed in their context and presentation. This is called Decoding.
 - Messages have both base rates and exemplars and a media literate person can discern the difference between the two.
 - Messages are now 'read' in the real sense.

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

1. Five Core Concepts of media literacy are:
 - All media messages are 'constructed.'
 - Media messages are constructed using a creative language with its own rules.
 - Different people experience the same media message differently.
 - Media have embedded values and points of view.
 - Most media messages are organised to gain power.
2. At different points of time the content and treatment is decided by various stakeholders in media business. The decision making is done at the individual and organisational level keeping in mind the profits. However, some decisions

are taken at a level which lies in the sub conscious mind in the form of stereotypes and biases. These decisions are not just taken by the creator of media messages but also the receivers of the same.

3. The benefits gained from the media messages are not only in terms of financial gain. All the participants of the media message process will gain from the messages if they understood how to read, understand and create media messages. The public gains when it is media literate and is able to distinguish between the real and the contrived. It also gains when it can see through propaganda, publicity, advertisement, and storytelling. Private interests are limited to media owners at the financial level but at the personal level each participant gains through one's ability to give and take media messages. Media houses gain in terms of finances and also in terms of power. If a media house is able to get the audience to tune into its programmes day after day, it is able to sell space to the advertisers at a good rate and make profit. The media house can also tailor messages to suit a certain political ideology, a life philosophy, a lifestyle or an image. This way, in a democratic country mass media messages can be used to tilt the power equation towards the highest bidder.



ignou
THE PEOPLE'S
UNIVERSITY

UNIT -15 RIGHT TO INFORMATION

Structure

- 15.0 Introduction
- 15.1 Learning Outcomes
- 15.2 Right to Information: Concept & Evolution
- 15.3 Right to Information Act, 2005
- 15.4 Right to Information and Indian Constitution
- 15.5 Institutions Covered under RTI
 - 15.5.1 Information to be given by the public authorities
 - 15.5.2 Information which cannot be accessed by the public
- 15.6 Impact of Right to Information
- 15.7 Constraints in Implementing RTI
- 15.8 Right to Information (Amendment) Act, 2019
- 15.9 Let Us Sum Up
- 15.10 References and Further Readings
- 15.11 Answer to Check Your Progress Exercises

15.0 INTRODUCTION

In a democratic set-up, information is an indispensable tool of good governance which acts as an aid to ensure accountability in administration. If people are not aware about the actions of those who rule them, they cannot take a meaningful part in the affairs of the society. In this regard, the Right to Information Act, 2005 was passed by the government for access to information and to ensure accountability and transparency in governance.

This Unit gives you an overview of various aspects of the Right to Information Act, 2005 such as the historical development of the RTI in India, and the salient features of the Act. It looks at the impact of RTI in checking corruption and also examines various constraints in implementing the Act. The unit briefly touches upon the RTI (Amendment) 2019 which gives power to the government to set the tenure and salaries of the state and central information commissioners.

15.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this Unit, you should be able to:

- describe the historical evolution of the Right to Information in India (RTI);
- analyse the impact of RTI;
- describe some constraints in implementing RTI;
- discuss the focus of RTI (Amendment) 2019; and
- examine the issues related to the implementation of RTI in India.

15.2 RIGHT TO INFORMATION: CONCEPT & EVOLUTION

Information is crucial for vibrant democracy, good governance, accountable administration and overall transparent system. Access to information is equally important as dissemination of information. Access to information not only facilitates active participation of people in the democratic governance process, but also promotes openness, sincerity and merit in the entire system. Right to Information Act, 2005 is a great step in this endeavour. The Act can be used for securing access to information under the control of public authorities and to promote transparency and accountability in the working of every public authority so as to usher in good governance.

Media makes use of RTI to access credible and authentic information and report news/facts accurately and objectively. Being a powerful tool in the hands of media, the right to information heralds a new age of investigative journalism and create a paradigm shift in building trust between people and the state and a harmonious relationship between the two.

According to RTI Act, 2005, the term “right to information” means the right to information accessible under this Act. This deals with the information held by or under the control of any public authority and includes the right to —

- inspection of work, documents, records;
- taking notes, extracts or certified copies of documents or records;
- taking certified samples of material;
- obtaining information in the form of diskettes, floppies, tapes, video cassettes or in any other electronic mode or through printouts where such information is stored in a computer or in any other device;
- It is essential to note that only that information which already exists and is held by the public authority or held under the control of the public authority is given under the RTI Act.

Historical Development of Right to Information

The commitment towards a transparent and accountable government is not confined to India but various countries across the globe have enacted laws and legislations to make information accessible to public. The first RTI law was enacted by Sweden in 1766, largely motivated by the parliament’s interest in access to information held by the King. Finland was the next to adopt, in 1951, followed by the United States, which enacted its first law in 1966, and Norway, which passed its laws in 1970. At present more than 85 countries, including UK, France, Australia, New Zealand and Canada, Greece, Austria, Italy, etc. have enacted national level RTI laws.

In India, the misuse of authority and power by the government during the time of Internal Emergency of 1975–77 led to expression for citizen’s right to information in 1977. However the real quest for the Act began in 1990 when Mazdoor Kisan Sangathan in Rajasthan started a movement for RTI in which they demanded the information regarding the development work carried in rural areas. With the result, RTI Act was enacted in Rajasthan in 2000. Earlier Tamil Nadu was the

first state to enact a law on RTI in 1997 while Delhi had RTI Act in 2001.

Expressing the intent of an informed citizenry the government introduced the Freedom of Information Bill, 2000 in the Parliament which was halted for about two years and was finally passed by the Parliament in December 2002. It received the assent of the President of India in January 2003. However, the Act contained certain loopholes due to which it was criticised on various grounds and was not notified.

In 2004 the central government constituted the National Advisory Council (NAC) for advising the government and finally, in 2004 the RTI Bill was introduced in the Parliament and it received the assent of the President in 2005.

15.3 RIGHT TO INFORMATION ACT, 2005

The intent and objective of the Right to Information Act, 2005 has been significantly mentioned in its preamble which states that it is “an Act to provide for setting out the practical regime of right to information for citizens to secure access to information under the control of public authorities, in order to promote transparency and accountability in the working of every public authority”. Further, it is stated that the Constitution of India has established democratic Republic; and democracy requires an informed citizenry and transparency of information which are vital to its functioning and also to contain corruption.

Salient Features of RTI Act

The Act promises to make the right to information more progressive, participatory and meaningful, as it encourages the common citizen to enthusiastically participate in the whole process of governance. The citizens are not only free to ask for information from the government but also have the right to get it.

The scope of the Act extends to all authorities and bodies under the Constitution of India. The Act extends to Central and state governments and local bodies. The Non-Governmental organisations (NGOs) substantially funded, directly or indirectly, by the public funds also fall within the ambit of this Act.

A duty has been cast, in Section 4 of the Act, on every public authority to suo motu provide to the public with the information as prescribed. A citizen has to merely make a request to the concerned Public Information Officer (PIO) specifying the information sought by him. The fee payable is reasonable and the information is to be provided free of cost to citizens living below the poverty line.

To ensure that the information sought is provided quickly, Section 7 of the Act makes it mandatory for the PIO to provide the information within 30 days. If the information requested concerns the life or liberty of a person, it has been made mandatory to provide it within 48 hours of the receipt of the request. The Act provides for penalties in case of failure to provide information in time, or for refusing to accept an application for information, or for giving incorrect, incomplete or misleading information, or destroying information and so on. In addition, the Information Commission has also been empowered to recommend disciplinary action against the government servants.

The Act establishes an appeal system too. The first appeal lies to an officer within the organisation who is senior in rank to PIO. The second appeal lies in the Information Commission.

In the case of security and intelligence agencies and organisations, which are exempted from the provisions of this Act, if there were cases of allegation of corruption and human rights violation, such exemption would not be available. In cases of allegations of violation of human rights, information would be made available after the approval of the Information Commission.

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) What is the time limit for PIOs for providing information?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) Whether NGOs are covered under RTI Act, 2005?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

3) What is in the preamble of the Act ?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

15.4 RIGHT TO INFORMATION AND INDIAN CONSTITUTION

The right to information has been considered as a part of constitutional law of the country after the writ petitions has been filed by the print media in the Supreme Court seeking enforcements of certain logistical implication of the right to freedom of speech and expression and challenging governmental orders for control of newsprint, bans on distribution of paper etc.

In the case of People's Union for Civil Liberties vs Union of India AIR 2004 SC 1442 : (2004) 2 SCC 476, it was held that "Right to Information is a facet of the freedom of 'speech and expression' as contained in Article 19 (1) (a) of the Constitution of India. Right to Information, thus, indisputably is a Fundamental Right."

In State of U.P. vs. Raj Narain case (1975) 4 SCC 428, it has been held by the Supreme Court that "in a Government of responsibility like ours, where all the agents of the public must be responsible for their conduct, there can be but few secrets. The people of this country have a right to know every public act, everything that is done in a public way, by their public functionaries. They are entitled to know the particulars of every public transaction in all its bearing".

In S. P. Gupta vs. Union of India (1981) Supp SCC 87, the Supreme Court recognized that a democratic society cannot keep the activities of the government hidden from the public in order to avoid accountability and criticism. Recognizing a "right to know which seems implicit in the right of free speech and expression," the Court said: "Where a society has chosen to accept democracy as its creedal faith, it is elementary that the citizens ought to know what their government is doing. The citizens have a right to decide by whom and by what rules they shall be governed and they are entitled to call on those who govern on their behalf to account for their conduct. No democratic government can survive without accountability and the basic postulate of accountability is that the people should have information about the functioning of the government. It is only if people know how government is functioning that they can fulfill the role which democracy assigns to them and make democracy a really effective participatory democracy"

In Secretary, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting vs. Cricket Association of Bengal, the Supreme Court held in 1995 that "The right to participate in the affairs to the country is meaningless unless the citizens are well informed on all sides of the issues, in respect of which they are called upon to express their views. One-sided information, misinformation and non- information all equally create an uninformed citizenry which makes democracy a farce ..."

15.5 INSTITUTIONS COVERED UNDER RTI

According to the RTI Act, all public authorities are obligated to provide the information to the citizens. Here "public authority" means any authority or body or institution of self-government established or constituted—

- by or under the Constitution;
- by any other law made by the Parliament;
- by any other law made by State Legislature;
- by notification issued or order made by the appropriate government, and includes any—
 - i. body owned, controlled or substantially financed; and
 - ii. Non-Government Organisation substantially financed, directly or indirectly by funds provided by the appropriate Government.

15.5.1 Information to be given by the public authorities

All public authorities after the enactment of the Act are mandated to publish the following information every year:

- i. The particulars of its organisation, functions and duties;
- ii. The powers and duties of its officers and employees;
- iii. The procedure followed in the decision making process, including channels of supervision and accountability;
- iv. The norms set by it for the discharge of its functions;
- v. The rules, regulations, instructions, manuals and records, held by it or under its control or used by its employees for discharging its functions;
- vi. A directory of its officers and employees;
- vii. The names, designations and other particulars of the Public Information Officers; and
- viii. Other prescribed information.

15.5.2 Information which cannot be accessed by the public

There are certain areas of information which have been kept out of the purview of the Act. They include:

- a) Information disclosure of which would prejudicially affect the sovereignty and integrity of India, or relations with foreign State or that may lead to incitement of an offence;
- b) Information which has been expressly forbidden to be published by any court of law or tribunal or the disclosure of which may constitute contempt of court;
- c) Information the disclosure of which would cause a breach of privilege of the Parliament or the State Legislature;
- d) Information, including commercial confidence, trade secrets or intellectual property, the disclosure of which would harm the competitive position of a third party, unless the competent authority is satisfied that larger public interest warrants the disclosure of such information;
- e) Information received in confidence from foreign government;
- f) Information which would impede the process of investigation or apprehension or prosecution of offenders;
- g) Cabinet papers, including records of deliberations of the Council of Ministers, Secretaries and other officers; and (h) Information which would cause unwarranted invasion of the privacy of the individual unless the Central Public Information Officer or the State Public Information Officer or the appellate authority, as the case may be, is satisfied that the larger public interest justifies the disclosure of such information.

15.6 IMPACT OF RIGHT TO INFORMATION

The Right to Information Act, 2005 has not only strengthened the right to know of an individual but also mandated the public authorities to be more accountable

and transparent in their functioning. This is now a tool used by responsible citizens as well media to bring out many hidden scams and malfunctioning of the public machinery. The impact of the legislation can be put under the following heads:

- I. Promoted an informed citizenry:** The Act provided the people with the mechanism to access information, which can be utilized by them to seek explanations and to ask about the decisions taken by them and the consequences of those decisions. The citizens can now inquire about the schemes and policies of the government which has been created for them. According to the provisions of the Act, the authorities are also mandated to upload the necessary information for access to citizens in their official website.
- II. Promotion of citizen-government partnership:** The RTI Act provides a framework for the promotion of citizen-government partnership in carrying out the programmes for the welfare of the people. The principle of partnership is derived from the fact that people are not only the ultimate beneficiaries of development but also the agents of development. The stakeholders' participation leads to better projects and more dynamic development. Under the RTI regime, citizens' participation has been promoted through access to information and involvement of affected groups/communities in the design and implementation of projects. The disclosure of information has enabled the beneficiaries to assume a central role in the design and execution of projects.
- III. Reduction in corruption:** Lack of transparency and accountability encourages government officials to indulge in corrupt practices. Due to RTI regime, there is greater transparency in the working of public departments. As a result, there is a better understanding of the decision-making process and greater accountability of government. According to Transparency International (TI), RTI Act has been playing a major role in the decline of corruption in India.

Impact of RTI: Some Examples

It will be useful for you to look at some examples of the impact of the RTI Act:

Crawford Market Redevelopment: According to a 12 October 2009 report of Hindustan Times '4 yrs on, RTI goes strong', the RTI Act was used to uncover the Rs 1,000 crore loss which the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation was ready to incur by letting a private developer undertake the Crawford Market redevelopment.

Mani Lal Ratan (2019) state editor of Dainik Bhaskar, Raipur, gave several examples relating to impact of RTI in his book. Some of them are given below:

Management Institute's Admission Criteria Vaishnavi Kasturi a visually-impaired student, in 2007 was denied a seat in one of the country's premier management institutes – despite her impressive score at the entrance examination. Ms. Kasturi wanted to know why, and wondered whether it was because of her physical disability. She filed an RTI application to request the institute to disclose their selection process. Although she failed to gain admission to the institute, her RTI application meant that IIM had to make its admission criteria public. It emerged that the entrance exam, the Common Admission Test, actually mattered little compared to Class 10 and 12 results.

Adarsh Society Scam

The applications filed by RTI activists were instrumental in bringing to light links between politicians and military officials, among others. The 31- storey building, which had permission for six floors only, was originally meant to house war widows and veterans. Instead, the flats went to several politicians, bureaucrats and their relatives. The scandal led to the resignation of Ashok Chavan from the post of chief minister of Maharashtra.

Exorbitant expenditure on toilet construction

In the response to an RTI query by an activist in October 2012, she was told by the Basic Education Department that from April 2007 to October 2012, the Uttar Pradesh government had released Rs 3225.81 lakh for the construction of 1538 toilets, meaning thereby that toilets were constructed at the cost of more than Rs 2.09 lakh per toilet as against standard cost of Rs 24, 000 per unit of construction as fixed by Government of India. It was also revealed that out of Rs 3225.81 lakhs, Rs 1944 lakh were allocated to only district, Agra, meaning that more than 60% of total funds allocated for toilets went to one district. Rest 74 districts of U. P. got less than 40% share. Districts like Bijnor, Jyotiba Phule Nagar, Kashiram Nagar, Maharajganj, Shamli, Shrawasti, Sonebhadra and Chhatrapati Shahuji Maharaj Nagar got no money for toilet constructions in five years.

Foreign Jaunts: In 2009, Shyamlal Yadav, a Special Correspondent in India Today, got a prestigious award, for using RTI Act to expose foreign jaunts by ministers and junketeering by bureaucrats causing loss to the exchequer.

RTI Investigations carried out by Indian Express, Pune revealed that 377 babies died in Sassoon, YCM hospital NICUs in Feb. 2011. RTI query revealed deaths of 377 babies in the neo-natal intensive care units. Major causes of death were respiratory distress syndrome, sepsis, asphyxia and congenital diseases. In Sassoon burns ward: 3000 women admitted in 5 years, 1900 succumbed. RTI investigation revealed ventilators, ICU, Operation theatre missing; non-functional air conditioners, shortage of staff and medicines.

Thus RTI Act gave ordinary citizens the right to ask questions to government authorities and equipped them with some means to take on corruption

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) What is the relationship of Adarsh Society scam in Maharashtra and RTI?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) What was decided by the Supreme Court in PUCL vs. Union of India case?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

3) What are Transparency International views about RTI in India?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

15.7 CONSTRAINTS IN IMPLEMENTING RTI

There are various constraints in implementing RTI. Among the factors that have impacted the gains made under the RTI regime are:

- Exclusion of departments and organisations from the purview of RTI
- The manner in which information is structured and organized
- The time frame in which information is provided
- Preparedness of public bodies to provide information
- Monitoring and enforcement of the RTI Act

Several civil liberties activists feel that it is the government and the judiciary that together pose a “serious threat to the RTI” as suggested by a former Central Information Commissioner Shailesh Gandhi. He has said that the government’s infrastructure such as training and resources for the implementation of the RTI is “woefully inadequate.” He also added that the manner in which courts had been granting stays on orders of the information commission indicated a “dangerous trend.”

A study by the Right to Information Assessment and Analysis Group (RaaG) has indicated that nearly 60 per cent of the commissions reported inadequate infrastructure as their biggest problem. Inadequate staff and low budgets were the most commonly cited problems. According to Lal, “The main obstacle to the RTI fulfilling its potential is the attitude of bureaucrats who still treat it as a burden and provide information on a need-to-know basis. Transparency in governance also entails administrative reforms the authorities are reluctant to undertake.

The ineffectiveness of information commissions is another factor hampering the RTI. Activists have been opposing the government’s practice of appointing retired bureaucrats as information commissioners. Those who spent their professional lives opposing disclosure of information are unlikely to be votaries for access to information.”

There are some other constraints too in the effective implementation of RTI Act. They include:

Lack of basic infrastructure: The PIOs are required to provide information through photocopies, soft copies etc., but these facilities are not easily available at district level and therefore it becomes a challenge to get information from Block/Panchayat level. Also the limited use of information technology delays the procedure of providing information within the stipulated time.

Lack of qualitative information: The information which has been provided under the Act has been found dissatisfactory by the information seeker. According to the data, approximately 75 per cent people are not satisfied with the information provided by the authorities.

Information not provided within prescribed time limit: The Act sets down the deadline for providing information which is 30 days, but the information is not provided within 30 days in many cases.

Untrained PIOs and authorities: It has been observed that the PIOs lack basic training and are unaware of the recent RTI judgments. Also, the frequent transfers/changes in the PIOs adds to the challenge.

Pendency of RTI appeals: Just as the pendency of cases is increasing in our Indian courts every year, the pendency of RTI appeals is also on rise.

15.8 RIGHT TO INFORMATION (AMENDMENT) ACT, 2019

In July 2019, the Right to Information (Amendment) Bill, 2019 was passed by both Houses of Parliament giving the government powers to set salaries and service conditions for Information Commissioners. Later on the President of India gave his assent to the Bill.

It amended Section 13 (5) of the RTI Act. Before the amendment, Section 13(5) provided that salaries, allowances and other terms and conditions of the service of the Chief Information Commissioner shall be the same as that of the Chief Election Commissioner while that of an Information Commissioner shall be same as that of an Election Commissioner. According to the amendment, the term of offices, salaries and allowances and other terms and conditions shall be “as prescribed by the Central Government.” The argument given by the government was that “The functions being carried out by the Election Commission of India and the Central and State Information Commissions are totally different. The Election Commission of India is a Constitutional body; on the other hand Central Information Commission and State Information Commission are statutory bodies established under the right f Information Act 2005.”

The amendment has faced criticism from civil society members, activists and opposition parties who believe that the RTI architecture has been diluted and the move would take away independence of the commissions. The government, however, argues that it will put out as much information in the public domain as possible in order to reduce the need for RTI applications. The amendment would correct certain anomalies in the RTI Act and strengthen the overall RTI structure and there will be no interference in the independence and autonomy of the Act.

The Right to Information Act, 2005 is considered to be one of the most progressive and democracy - enhancing legislation enacted in free India. The Act gave ordinary citizens the right to ask questions to government authorities and acted as a deterrent for government servants against taking arbitrary decisions. According to estimates, nearly 60 lakh applications are being filed every year by common people as well as the media.

The relevance of the Act lies in providing information to public by the authorities. The CIC, in its various cases, tried to widen the scope and ambit of the Act, but the ineffective enforcement of the orders leaves the objective of transparent administration unfulfilled. There is a great need to widen the scope of RTI Act. Private schools and institutions, which are often reported for their arbitrary administration, are also excluded from the purview of RTI Act and so are cooperative societies. Only those entities which are substantially aided by the government can be brought under RTI. At present Political parties are also out of the scope of RTI Act. Some of these steps will contribute to the effectiveness of the RTI Act enabling it to usher in greater transparency at various levels and strengthen the foundations of democracy.

Check Your Progress Exercise 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) What is the major focus of the RTI (Amendment) Act 2019?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) If any court of law forbids any information to make public, can that be obtained through RTI Act?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

3) What are the infrastructural problems at block/ panchayat level to provide information under RTI?

.....

.....

.....

.....

15.9 LET US SUM UP

The RTI Act is considered as one of the most successful laws which gave ordinary citizens the right to ask questions to government authorities and equipped them with some means to take on corruption. The Unit provides an overview of the Right to Information Act, 2005 which has now become an indispensable part of good governance. The Act is a central legislation passed by Parliament of India. The legislation also provides penal provisions against public officers in case of non-compliance of the provisions of the Act. Several Supreme Court judgments also support right to know, i.e. right to information for Indian citizens. At present political parties and several private institutions serving public are out of the purview of the RTI Act, 2005.

With the help of some examples, the unit explained how the RTI Act has been successful in exposing corruption in India. However, like any other legislation, the RTI Act has also problems in its effective implementation which need to be addressed. With the advancement of time, there is a need to enlarge its scope for greater transparency and accountability. The existing loopholes need to be removed to ensure its proper implementation to meet the objective of the Act.

In July 2019, the RTI Act was amended which gave power to the government to set the tenure and salaries of the state and central information commissioners. The government view is that the amendment would strengthen and streamline the RTI Act and remove some existing anomalies; while the activists argue that the government would interfere with the functioning of RTI thus affect its autonomy.

Understanding of the RTI Act is important for you as can use it to assert your right to information which is also your fundamental right incorporated under Freedom of Speech and Expression, as enshrined in Article 19(1) (a) of our Constitution of India.

15.10 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

Mani Lal Ratan. 2019. Right to Information: Towards Transparent Governance. *Kindle Edition*

Ashish K. S. Massey and Anshuman K.S. Massey. (2015). Law Relating to Right to Information

New Delhi: Orient Publishing Company. Second Edition (2015, Reprint 2016).

P. K. Das. 2016. Handbook on the Right to Information Act, (Fourth Edition) New Delhi: Universal Law Publishing Company.

Nandini Sahai and Vishnu Rajgadga. 2008. Right to Information: A Step By Step Guide - Publisher: FES-India, MICCI and UNESCO.

15.11 ANSWER TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS EXERCISE

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

- 1) The Act makes it mandatory for the PIO to provide the information within 30 days. If the information requested concerns the life or liberty of a person, it has been made mandatory to provide it within 48 hours of the receipt of the request.

- 2) The Non-Governmental Organisations (NGOs) substantially funded, directly or indirectly, by the public funds also fall within the ambit of the RTI Act, 2005.
- 3) The preamble states that it is “an Act to provide for setting out the practical regime of right to information for citizens to secure access to information under the control of public authorities, in order to promote transparency and accountability in the working of every public authority”. Further, it is stated that the Constitution of India has established democratic Republic; and democracy requires an informed citizenry and transparency of information which are vital to its functioning and also to contain corruption.

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

- 1) The applications filed by RTI activists were instrumental in bringing to light links between politicians and military officials, among others. The 31-storey building, which had permission for six floors only, was originally meant to house war widows and veterans. Instead, the flats went to several politicians, bureaucrats and their relatives. The scandal led to the resignation of Ashok Chavan from the post of chief minister of Maharashtra.
- 2) In *People’s Union for Civil Liberties vs Union of India* AIR 2004 SC 1442: (2004) 2 SCC 476, it was held that “Right to Information is a facet of the freedom of ‘speech and expression’ as contained in Article 19 (1) (a) of the Constitution of India. Right to Information, thus, indisputably is a Fundamental Right.”
- 3) According to Transparency International (TI), RTI Act has been playing a major role in the decline of corruption in India.

Check Your Progress Exercise 3

- 1) According to the amendment, the term of offices, salaries and allowances and other terms and conditions shall be as prescribed by the Central Government.
- 2) Information which has been expressly forbidden to be published by any court of law or tribunal or the disclosure of which may constitute contempt of court, cannot be obtained through RTI Act.
- 3) The PIOs are often required to provide information through photocopies, soft copies etc. At block/panchayat level the offices are not well equipped and therefore it becomes a challenge to get information from there. The limited use of information technology also delays the procedure of providing information within the stipulated time.

UNIT 16 CIVIC REPORTING

Structure

- 16.0 Introduction
- 16.1 Learning Outcomes
- 16.2 New trend in Reporting: Civic Journalism
 - 16.2.1 Features of Civic Journalism
- 16.3 Characteristics, Strengths and Limitations
 - 16.3.1 Learning about Civic Journalism
 - 16.3.2 The Truth about Civic Journalism
- 16.4 New Ethics in Civic Reporting
- 16.5 Platform to Speak
- 16.6 Citizen Journalism Vs Professional Journalism: Responsibility, Adventure and Political Power
- 16.7 Top sites of Citizen Journalism
 - 16.7.1 Case Study
- 16.8 Let Us Sum Up
- 16.9 References and Further Readings
- 16.10 Answer to Check Your Progress Exercises

16.0 INTRODUCTION

Civic journalism (also known as public journalism) is the idea of incorporating journalism into the democratic process. The media not only informs the public, but it also works towards involving citizens and creating public debate. The new trend of journalism and democracy not only challenge together the orthodoxy arguments of traditional reporting, they also open up a new frontier for an alternative. It approaches with more optimistic evaluation of the contemporary public sphere and its contribution to the social and political process. Journalism and Democracy combines textual analysis and extensive in-depth journalism. In this chapter this new trend of democratic journalism will be discussed. 'Civic or Public Journalism' is a genuinely fresh trend, with an expression of public opinion. So, Civic journalism is the idea of integrating journalism into the democratic process (also known as public journalism). The new media not only informs the public, but it also works towards engaging citizens and creating public information forum or debate. The civic reporting is an attempt to unrestraint the belief that journalists and their audiences are only spectators in political and social processes. The civic journalism treats readers as participants. With a small but committed following, civic journalism has become as much of a philosophy as it is a practice. Civic Journalism is "a fundamental change in the way of modern media business".

16.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this Unit, you should be able to:

- describe civic journalism and its use;
- describe the strengths and limitations of civic journalism as a media tool ;

- analyze the developments of civic journalism;
- discuss the various aspects of civic journalism; and
- study the effect of civic journalism.

16.2 NEW TREND IN REPORTING: CIVIC JOURNALISM

What do we mean by public journalism or Civic Reporting? Its definition has been a point of argument throughout. It's a form of journalism that seeks to listen systematically to the stories and ideas of citizens even while protecting its freedom to choose whatever it wants to cover. It is an alternative way to frame stories on important community issues, and the best chance to inspire citizen deliberation and build public understanding of issues.

The traditional concept of journalism is gathering, assessing, creating news and information and disseminating the information to all. Journalism has diverse characteristics and practices. The new or modern media has brought a profound change in the interpretation of journalism. Civic journalism is an effort to reach out to the public more aggressively in the reporting process, to listen to how citizens frame their problems and what citizens see as solutions to those problems. Then, the other mainstream journalist can use that information to enrich news stories. Civic journalism is practiced by newspapers, radio and television stations in many developed countries around the world.

Decades later Dewey's argument was further explored by Jay Rosen and Davis Merritt, who were looking at the importance of the media in the democratic process. In 1993, Rosen and Merritt formed the concept of public journalism. In their joint "manifesto" on public journalism that was published in 1994, Rosen explained, "public journalism tried to place the journalist within the political community as a responsible member with a full stake in public life." But it does not deny the important difference between journalists and citizens themselves. In a word, public journalists want public life to work. The question remains whether public journalism represents a radical movement or a return to tradition.

16.2.1 Features of Civic Journalism

The most prominent characteristic of the works on public journalism is its contentiousness. It deals with public journalism's goals, performance in implementing its goals, relation to democratic theory, the nature of practice, or the impact on communities. Today understanding the features of civic journalism or civic reporting has helped the people become aware of detailed news of serious and not so serious incidents.

"Citizen Journalism or Civic reporting" is one of those phrases that sound pretty straightforward. But, when a non-reporter gets to report an incident, most people aren't exactly sure what it means. Basically, a citizen journalist is someone from outside the news business who engages in the kind of journalism that is traditionally the purview of the professional journalist.

Today the communication system has digitally upgraded the media. In a digital world there is a complete host of different ways to communicate. Today, the value of amateur eyewitness film shot on a mobile phone and posted on the

internet has added news value to the normal incidents. At times its popularity and usage has no less news value than a broadcast on a traditional television channel or published on a website.

Controlling how news is reported and disseminated is closely linked to power. That's the reason why dictatorships have always iron handedly censored or removed the free press and run state TV stations. While much of the western world has moved ahead from that, media is often controlled by a certain group, making citizen journalism a vital part of opening up of reporting to everyone. But if it truly makes a lasting impact for good, citizen journalists need to understand their own responsibilities. Civic reporters should not to be biased, abide by the ethics and law and act accordingly.

Despite the potential drawbacks, there are plenty of reasons to welcome the rise of citizen journalism. The running term "Every Citizen is a Reporter," has become an influential news resource in new media. Citizen journalism on the internet has also added blogs, chat rooms and message boards. All stripes provide a range of opinion and reporting far beyond what traditional news outlets can offer.

16.3 CHARACTERISTICS, STRENGTHS AND LIMITATIONS

What advantages and disadvantages do citizen journalists have over mainstream media?

The popularisation of new technologies including blog sites, social networks, and the use of smart phones with cameras, allow members of the public without any journalistic training to participate and publish their own point of view about a range of subjects. Articles written by citizen journalists may contain anything within or even outside the news; however there have been debates as to whether this type of journalism is good or bad for mainstream media?

Some advantages of citizen journalism are

- a) The members of public are able to alert the media to news stories that they may not already know about, or that professional journalists have difficulty to cover.
- b) Citizen journalists can be a massive help by providing written reports in addition to photographs and videos in real time. For example many stories regarding the Arab Spring have been covered by citizen journalists when mainstream media were unable to reach areas of conflict or a media blackout was in place.
- c) Smaller newspapers often need to rely on citizen journalists for the latest updates, due to their low staff count.
- d) Such kind of reporting produces evidence from the field and without any biasness, ready to create a direct public opinion.

Disadvantages

- a) Citizen journalists are not professionally trained, so subjectivity or bias may creep in their stories.
- b) Sometimes such stories may be of poor standard, and lack content.

- c) They may also not be aware of journalistic ethics which is a serious concern in any treat reporting.
- d) The use of freedom of speech by a citizen journalist may result in libel. There were a member of cases in the past when people have been charged for statements they have published via social networks or online blogs as they were offensive or untrue.

Yet, citizen journalists complement mainstream media by providing speedier reports and information from a range of sources that allow mainstream media reports to be balanced cover more aspects and be more accurate.

What are the strengths and weaknesses of citizen journalism and user-generated content?

The mass media is an open public space where individuals are able to communicate freely the particular meanings about the world in which they live. Social networking sites, blogs, user-generated content sites and the like have brought tremendous wealth to our cultural industry and, in turn, these spaces have empowered active audiences, further revolutionising the process of communication. It can be said that an audience's utilisation of new media is integral to revolutionising the process of public communication.

Instead of isolating the consumer (readers/ viewers) from the production process, these media networks, as noted by Professor Robert Cover (author of Audience inter/active: Interactive media, narrative control and reconceiving audience history), provide consumers with 'a digital power'. This environment fosters greater capacity and greater interest by allowing audiences to change, alter and manipulate a text or a textual narrative, to seek co-participation in authorship, and to thus redefine the traditional author-text-audience relationship. In this sense, interactivity empowers users to engage in society in innovative ways and it provides individuals with a space where they are able to freely communicate particular meanings and ideas. This empowers them to be individual reporters.

Participatory forms of media, like blogging, have enabled audiences to become empowered and activated by 'identifying with the producer of the text.' They feel involved in the production of the show, and in doing so they can make decisions about its content and direction.

The strength of such media is that information is communicated almost instantly. As the event unfolds facts and photographs are communicated promptly. Often this sort of critical information may be different from what the journalist has captured. Journalists arrive at the scene in the after the incident and in such situations a citizen journalist can provide material to the networks. Civic journalism can fill in the gaps that the reporter cannot fulfill the same.

Their stories often lack critical new values and may not be of high quality. Extreme variations in a particular story can be taken seriously and may result in harsh legal consequences.

A powerful example of citizen journalism is the footage that was captured of a young Iranian woman, Neda Agha-Sultan, who was brutally killed during the post-election protests in Tehran. A dramatic 40 second video of Neda's death was uploaded on YouTube and went viral.

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) Features of Civic Journalism.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) List disadvantages of Civic reporting.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

3) What are the strengths of citizen journalism?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

16.3.1 Learning about Civic Journalism

According to the now dormant Pew Center for Civic Journalism, the practice “is both a philosophy and a set of values supported by some evolving techniques to reflect both of these in journalism. At its heart is a belief that journalism has an obligation to public life – an obligation that goes beyond just telling the news or unloading lots of facts. The way we do our journalism affects the way public life goes.” Leading organisations in the field also include the Kettering Foundation, the Participatory Journalism Interest Group (formerly named the Civic and Citizen Journalism Interest Group) in the Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC) and the Public Journalism Network. Although they developed the concept of public journalism together, both Rosen and Merritt have differing viewpoints on what exactly public journalism is. Rosen explains five ways to understand public journalism:

- As an argument, a way of thinking about what journalist should be doing, given their own difficulty and general state of public life.
- As an experiment, a way of breaking out of established routines and making a different kind of contribution to public life.

- As a movement involving practicing journalists, former journalists who want to improve their craft, academics and researchers with ideas to lend and studies that might help, foundations and think tanks that gave financial assistance and sanctuary to the movement, and other likeminded folk who wanted to contribute to the rising spirit of reform.
- As a debate with often heated conversation within the press and with others outside it about the proper role of the press.
- As an adventure, an open-ended and experimental quest for another kind of press Merritt, on the other hand, explains that it is the responsibility of the journalist to act as a fair-minded participant in the public arena. His famous analogy of the journalist having the same role as a sports referee best depicts this idea:

The function of a third party – a referee or umpire or judge – in sports competition is to facilitate the deciding of the outcome. Ideally, the official impinges on the game; if things go according to the rules is that the referee is neither seen nor heard. Yet the presence of a fair-minded participant is necessary for an equitable decision to be reached. What he or she brings to the arena is knowledge of the agreed-upon rules, the willingness to contribute that knowledge, and authority – that is, the right to be attended to. The referee’s role is to make sure that the process works as the contestants agreed it should. In order to maintain that authority, that right to be heard, the referee must exhibit no interest in the final score other than it is arrived at under the rules. But, both for referees and contestants, that is the ultimate interest. It is important to remember that the referee doesn’t make the rules. Those are agreed on by the contestants – in this case, the democratic public. The referee, rather, is the fair-minded caretaker. What the journalist should bring to the arena of public life is the knowledge of the rules – how the public has decided a democracy should work and the ability and the willingness to provide relevant information and a lace for that information to be discussed and turned into democratic consent. Like the referee, to maintain our authority – the right to be heard – we must exhibit no partisan interest in the specific outcome other than it is arrived at under the democratic process.

Merritt summed up civic journalism as “a set of values about the craft that recognizes and acts upon the interdependence between journalism and democracy. It values the concerns of citizens over the needs of the media and political actors, and conceives of citizens as stakeholders in the democratic process rather than as merely victims, spectators or inevitable adversaries. As inherent participants in the process, we should do our work in ways that aid in the resolution of public problems by fostering broad citizen engagement.”

16.3.2 The Truth about Civic Journalism

Civic reporting has become an integral part of journalism. Daily newspapers and network television, particularly the evening news shows are competing for circulation and market share challenges with the supply of online news. The civic reporters are in no way lagging behind then the professional news makers in producing news stories. Many of them are convinced that the best solution lies in something called “civic journalism.”

The concept of Civic journalism actually, is a little vague — a little esoteric. According to Pew Center for Civic Journalism. “Civic journalism is an effort by

print and broadcast journalists to reach out to the public more aggressively in the reporting process, to listen to how citizens frame their problems and what citizens see as solutions to those problems. Then, use that information to enrich their newspaper or broadcast report. It is being practiced by newspapers and television stations in many cities, big and small.”

All civic reporting promotes a subtle and narrow ideological viewpoint. It’s hardly what you would call traditional reporting that strives for balance, if not objectivity.

In fact, civic journalism is just a component of a much broader political agenda called the New Citizenship movement — a movement defined by a document called the Civic Declaration, written by Harry C. Boyte. The Civic Declaration claims credit for introducing the idea of “civic journalism.” According to Boyte, it is “aimed at bringing citizens into public discussions of politics and policy in a far more active fashion and to reconnect journalists to the communities they serve.

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) What are the five ways of Civic Journalism according to Rosen?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) What are the qualities of a civic reporter?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

16.4 NEW ETHICS IN CIVIC REPORTING

Reports written by Citizen Voice are published in a public forum. The Citizen Voices Project has given journalists a new perspective on how to cover urban political issues stepping across the traditional line of journalistic independence. On one side civic reporting is independent and detached reporting, and on the other side it is also about participation, advocacy, and activism.

A recent addition to the multi-sided pressures faced by the news industry (corporate media concentration and convergence, audience fragmentation, citizen journalism {bloggers}, fusing of news and entertainment, shifts in advertising revenue streams) is a growing international demand to restore an ethics of social

responsibility for both the print and electronic press so that the cultural diversity of the world may be fairly represented through stories, images and voices that are more inclusive.

The problem lies in focusing on the news media in urban settings. Researches assumed that mainstream journalism constructs the poor, immigrants, refugees, indigenous peoples, or other excluded groups through third person sources, and, it is assumed that mainstream journalism rarely includes the voices of marginalized groups or addresses them directly. Can the profession of journalism claim that it fulfills an ethical mandate to inform its audience of the diversity of cultural expressions, which exist on the frontiers of the dominant group?

Civic journalism seeks to reduce the gap between groups being reported on and the journalist's implied audience by developing stories from where the subject (citizen or non-citizen) is situated. There is a need to develop a new set of ethics for civic journalism. The new ethics would hold journalism as a mediator of an ongoing public conversation among diverse groups rather than as a provider of neutral descriptions of agents, events, and issues. This will be deepened through the first innovation in methodology which is the diagnosis and putting into question of genealogies of how subjects are conventionally framed. The second level of innovation contrasts genealogical critique of mainstream news framing with a blending of more inclusive storytelling techniques and pedagogical alternatives that will be tested through field experiments with practitioners, communities, and researchers.

This approach may involve several disciplines to create new principles of dialogue between journalists, the excluded, and news-media audiences. The initial mixture includes journalism, sociology, communications, anthropology, and history.

16.5 PLATFORM TO SPEAK

Citizen journalism has been taken to a whole new level with the creation of websites that are written by citizen journalists with main focus on obtaining information important to their local area. Often these news stories may be silenced by mainstream media or may not be covered as such stories may not 'sell.' The creation of such sites enable the content producers to reach millions of people and also offers coverage of news that many news outlets are not able to cover.

American media critic Jay Rosen, who writes the blog pressthink.org, argues that Civic reporting is a power shift from professional journalism. People can talk back to the news system and make their own media. That's a power shift."

Indian context: Until recently, there was no sight of this 'power shift' in India. The mainstream press continued to outdo alternative forms of news expression like social media in popularity. Newspapers, news channels and news sites continued to relay the news; journalists continued to select and write it; and media owners may or may not tamper with it. And all the while, the public was largely a receptor.

Now ordinary people are increasingly reporting what they're witnessing, accidents, corruption, civic apathy and they're creating a network of micro-reports on social sites like Youtube and Facebook. They're editorialising on blogs and commenting on news sites. Their views are sought by mainstream press, and on

occasions, their first-hand reports and opinion pieces also make it to print. Citizen journalism is visibly on the rise.

“Citizen Journalism or civic reporting acquired the accoutrements of a movement in the early 2000s, particularly in the US,” points out veteran journalist Shishir Joshi. “But the origins of citizen journalism are as old as journalism, when pamphlets and reports were issued by citizens. Some of the most powerful pieces of journalistic writing can be traced back to the initiatives of citizens as reporters, not reporters as professionals.”

The advantage of citizen reporting is that it is not subject to someone’s control as stories are often killed if they are inconvenient to people at the top. Chances of censorship are fewer in citizen journalism. The mainstream media tend to privilege dominant voices that reproduce the status quo. Citizen journalism holds the promise of giving space to marginal voices and allowing for publication of alternate viewpoints.

This does not mean that citizen journalism wants no part of the mainstream press. On the contrary, senior journalists who run sites like citizens report in use their professional networks to circulate singular pieces to dailies like Mumbai Mirror, Hindustan Times and The Telegraph for greater impact.

Whatever the reasons may justify, civic reporting that is the participatory journalism is the future of news. From CCN’s iReport, to AFP’s stake in Citizenside to AP’s equity in Nowpublic.com, the big players have been quick to grasp the bilateral benefits of the exchange. In India news paper websites recently introduced a citizen’s section called NRI, where expats can post news about their outposts.

16.6 CITIZEN JOURNALISM VS PROFESSIONAL JOURNALISM: RESPONSIBILITY, ADVENTURE AND POLITICAL POWER

Citizen journalism might not be the product of a well-oiled mechanism and hence not that efficient, but it should have both conscience and compassion.

Civic reporting is a kind of collaborative relationship in which the information goes from the bottom; citizen journalist, up to professional ones. A civic reporter plays an important part in making the news whether it is breaking news or a featured item. But it is also true that it takes years of training and practice to become a journalist and the discipline is subject to code of practice, ethics and is governed by law. Anybody, aspiring to practice is expected to undergo training, but it is, unfortunately it is not the case for civic reporters.

- A civic reporter is a mere eye witness. Taking a picture, a video and giving an account of an event no matter how good the quality, does not make one a journalist but an eyewitness.
- A journalist will respect the rules of the profession even in photograph taking. Privacy will be respected as well as anonymity when a professional journalist reports, which might not be the case when citizen journalists report, resulting therefore in degrading the profession.

- Challenges such as one-sided views in politics and current affairs, publications of defamatory material frequent in citizen journalism practices tarnish journalism and portray professional journalist in bad light.
- New media technology such as social networking eg: Twitter, Facebook and Blogger, have given everyday citizens the ability to transmit information globally; a power which was once only reserved for large media corporations
- In addition, the increasing presence, speed and accessibility of advanced cellular phones and other media sharing devices has allowed citizen journalists to report on breaking news not only to a larger, global, audience, but also more quickly than traditional news reporters. Many believe this form of news coverage is fundamental to Journalism today; citizens' being relatable, unrestricted and available to capture images and footage of worldwide news as it breaks.
- Some argue that citizen journalists threaten to destroy the circulation of factual news, spreading incorrect, misleading information and opinion rather than truth. This is due to a suggested lack of training, ethics and accountability. However, citizen journalists have played a crucial role in news media over the last decade, stepping in for professional journalists in their absence to capture and distribute news material during major global events.
- Traditional journalism is the outside looking in and Citizen Journalism is the inside looking out. In Order to get the complete story, it helps to have both points of view. Is citizen journalism just an adventure treat or a political power of public opinion or a real responsibility? Can Civic reporting be coined as a reliable source of news and replace professional journalism? Or can both co-exist as different forms of reporting? These questions need to be thought over for the profession to do well in any society.

Check Your Progress Exercise 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) Why is ethics important in Civic Journalism?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) How can civic journalism be identified as a platform to speak?

.....

.....

.....

.....

- 3) Is it necessary to maintain collaboration between collaborative and traditional journalism work?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

16.7 TOP SITES OF CITIZEN JOURNALISM

The Third Report: The site is a hybrid of news aggregation and original content that allows one to write news and opinion, or refer to stories of interest.

CNN iReport: iReport invites you to share your story with CNN and the world.

Global Voices Online: The world is talking, are you listening?

Global Reporter: Tell the world what is happening in your community

Tingout: Tingout.com is a platform for citizen journalism where you can easily read and submit news from around the world. It hosts news from users and the major newspaper publishers. But if an official version does not convince you, you can launch a challenge and tell your truth.

360News: Citizen Journalism for the mobile internet age

Newzulu: Get paid for making your own video news.

Thedaily scholar.com: This is an excellent venue for posting op-eds, news, poetry, and debating topics.

16.7.1 Case Study

The rumor story of ‘Steve Jobs Heart Problem’ acts as a reminder of the dangers of publishing stories from anonymous, untrained sources. On October 3rd 2008, CNN posted on their citizen journalism site, iReport, ‘Steve Jobs rushed to ER following a severe heart attack’. The news turned out to be false; however, the damage was already done. Apples share price had dropped from \$105.27 to \$95.41 between 9:40am and 9:52am – a 9 per cent decrease within minutes. San Francisco Chronicle journalist, Reyhan Harmanci explained that the incident, “sparked debate about the accuracy of reports from these web sites.....showing how it takes only a few minutes for a scurrilous rumor, placed on a site without sufficient editorial checks, to inflict damage.”

The case at Boston Marathon bombing in 2013 when professional journalists heavily relied on citizens to enrich their narratives. Another example of their collaboration is embedded in the creation of TV and Radio programmes, Websites, blogs, Facebook, Twitter and YouTube accounts by mainstream media to allow people from around the globe to contribute pictures and videos of breaking news stories. With regards to mainstream media adopting alternative platform like, CNN, BBC, The Guardian and France 24 have respectively created i-Report, Your News, Guardian Witness and Reporters to stress the importance of the collaborative relationship between professional and citizen journalism. It receives daily, thousands of images from around the world of both major news events and

local issues. Video received from around the world included that of passenger Kim Dong-soo waiting to be rescued from the sinking South Korea ferry in April 2014. The video showed very calm people holding to anything they could when the ferry was sinking. Kim Dong-soo showed images that could not otherwise be broadcasted if there was no collaboration between the two types of journalism. The footage of Kim Dong-soo, and previous videos shown by professional journalists helped viewers better understand the story. The later example consolidates Dooley (2008)'s argument when he posits: traditional journalism is the outside looking in. Citizen journalism is the inside looking out. In order to get the complete story, it helps to have both points of view.

For the first time in the history of India the power of citizens through social media was seen and the impact was tremendous during the Delhi Gang Rape (Nirbhaya case) - that involved rape and murder of a 23-year-old woman, a physiotherapy intern who was beaten and gang raped in a bus in which she was travelling with her man companion on December 16, 2012 in New Delhi. The young girl died from her injuries thirteen days later while undergoing emergency treatment in Singapore. The media called the young victim 'Nirbhaya' - a brave heart. Nirbhaya's case was able to cut deep into the hearts of people irrespective of their caste, creed, religion or age, the incident made the general public's collective anger to explode and come out on streets. If not for collective efforts of the people, Nirbhaya incident would have been another case of violence in the capital city. The United Nations Human rights chief called rapes in India a "national problem."

The Nirbhaya case caught the attention of the entire main stream media but a new trend was witnessed and the power of Citizens through Citizen Journalism was actively playing a role. There was also a plethora of citizens on the ground reporting the developments as it happened and reported in Social Media and posted their videos and comments on twitter, the main stream added a section in their news bulletin and programs as "Citizen news & Views" and the comments on Twitter, you tube videos and so on. The Delhi gang rape demonstrated how citizen journalism has really come to the fore. Change.org, an online petition "Stop Rape Now" was initiated by former Journalist Namita Bhandare seeking the intervention of President Pranab Mukherjee and Chief Justice of India.

Today there are many channels having exclusive programs featuring reports and stories filed by Citizens called "Citizen Journalists" aiming at encouraging and creating a formal platform for Citizen Journalists like the popular show on TV channels like ibnlive and Headlines today that telecast - CJ Show and Right to be heard (RTH) on weekly basis and has gained popularity over a period of time. In addition to TV channels we have various websites like the Citizen Media Network an open forum, platform to nurture and promote Citizen Journalism from all walks of life to express themselves through new media tools and get trained in digital journalism methods and techniques. Popular websites like merinews.com, w.ww.reportindia.com, www.indiaonline.in.cj, www.mynews.in and many more websites give a platform for Citizen Journalists in India and South Asia.

16.8 LET US SUM UP

Citizen Journalism is journalism with democracy, active participation of citizens, politics, government and civic life. Civic reporting involves active participation

of citizens in newsgathering and reporting. At times play a multiple role of exposing corruption, encouraging accountability, documenting abuses of power, and giving alternative views on local and international current affairs.

Civic Reporting/citizen journalism is known to inform and educate and report from within a crisis so as to enrich traditional journalism for the general public to better understand the story. Civic reporting is also a reflection of personal emotion, opinion and or belief. This can be dangerous for objective news. So, collaborating with mainstream journalism will add value to it. In this unit, you have learnt that

- The primary aim of journalism is to be objective and present an unbiased, factual account of news events.
- A strict code of ethics is adhered to by all professional journalists when doing so to maintain and preserve public trust, confidence and reliability.
- To ensure this the process of 'gate keeping' is upheld within mainstream media.
- This relies on all experienced and trained journalists and editors to filter any nonfactual information from news reports before publication or broadcasting.
- Citizen journalists are untrained in such journalistic methods and are therefore at risk of using unreliable sources and publishing incorrect or infactual news.

16.9 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

Brain Mc Nair. 2000. Journalism and Democracy An evaluation of the political public sphere. London: Routledge

Dahlgren Peter and Sparks Colin. 1991. Communication and Citizenship Journalism and the Public Sphere. London: Routledge

Campbell Cole C. 1991. The Idea of Public Journalism. Guilford Press

Online Sources

<http://www.thetoptens.com/citizen-journalism-sites/>

<http://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/mumbai/The-citizen-as-reporter/articleshow/9254359.cms>

Case study : www.journalismthefuture.wordpress.com/citizen-journalism-vs-professional-journalism/ www.elon.edu/docs/eweb/academics/communications/research/vol6no1/04BroganEJSpring15.pdwww.jespnet.com/journals/Vol_1_No_1_June_2014/10pdf

16.10 ANSWER TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS EXERCISE

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

1) Features of Civic Journalism:

- literature on public journalism is its contentiousness
- presenting details news of serious and not so serious incidents

- someone from outside the news business who engages in the kind of journalism
- Every Citizen is a Reporter

2) List advantages of Civic reporting

- The members of public are able to alert the media to news stories that they may not already know about, or that professional journalists have not got the ability to cover.
- Citizen journalists can be a massive help by providing written reports in addition to photographs and videos in real time. For example many stories regarding the Arab Spring have been covered by citizen journalists when mainstream media were unable to reach areas of conflict or a media blackout was in place.
- Smaller newspapers often need to rely on citizen journalists for the latest updates, due to their low staff count.
- Civic reporting is straight evidence from the spot and without any biasness, ready to create a direct public opinion without an unfair outcome

3) What are the strengths of citizen journalism

- Information is communicated almost instantly.
- Civic journalism can fill in the gaps that the reporter could not.
- Critical information may be variably different to what the journalist has captured.
- Event unfolds; facts and photographs are communicated promptly.

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

1) What are the five ways of Civic Journalism according to Rosen

- As an argument, a way of thinking about what journalist should be doing, given own difficulty and general state of public life.
- As an experiment, a way of breaking out of established routines and making a different kind of contribution to public life.
- As a movement involving practicing journalists, former journalists who want to improve their craft, academics and researchers with ideas to lend and studies that might help, foundations and think tanks that gave financial assistance and sanctuary to the movement, and other likeminded folk who wanted to contribute to the rising spirit of reform.
- As a debate with often heated conversation within the press and with others outside it about the proper role of the press.
- As an adventure, an open-ended and experimental quest for another kind of press.

2) Qualities of Civic reporter

- The civic reporters are no way back then the professional news makers
- Civic journalism is an effort by print and broadcast journalists to reach out to the public
- Promoting solutions to problems, real and imagined.

- The real problem with journalism today is that it has become a public-relations tool for big government.

Check Your Progress Exercise 3

- 1) Why is ethics important in Civic Journalism?
 - It creates a polarizing effect and ignores the gray that most often exists between the black and white when you explore journalism ethics
 - A plan to create a network of interdisciplinary researchers and journalists who will develop a new ethics for civic journalism
 - The new ethics defines journalism as a mediator of an ongoing public conversation among diverse groups rather than as a provider of neutral descriptions of agents, events, and issues.
- 2) How can civic journalism be identified as a platform to speak?
 - Citizen journalists main focus is obtaining information important to their local area According to the amendment, the term of offices, salaries and allowances and other terms and conditions shall be as prescribed by the Central Government.
 - They are citizen - producers of the content
 - People can talk back to the news system and make their own media. That's a power shift."
 - Ordinary people are increasingly reporting as eye witness
- 3) Why is it necessary to maintain collaboration between collaborative and traditional journalism work?
 - Civic reporters are just mere eye witness and this cannot make one a journalist.
 - A journalist will respect the rules of the profession even in photograph taking.
 - Challenges such as one-sided views
 - New media technology such as social networking
 - The increasing presence, speed and accessibility have allowed citizen journalists to report on breaking news.
 - Some argue that citizen journalists threaten to destroy the circulation of factual news, spreading incorrect, misleading information and opinion rather than truth.
 - Traditional journalism is the outside looking in and Citizen Journalism is the inside looking out.

UNIT 17 MOBILE JOURNALISM

Structure

- 17.0 Introduction
- 17.1 Learning Outcomes
- 17.2 What is Mobile Journalism?
 - 17.2.1 Mobile Journalism and Citizen Journalists
 - 17.2.2 Strengths of Mobile Journalism
- 17.3 Tools and Accessories
 - 17.3.1 Equipment Required
 - 17.3.2 Mobile Applications
 - 17.3.3 Webcasting
- 17.4 Production Aspects of Mobile Journalism
 - 17.4.1 Shots
 - 17.4.2 Sequencing and Storyboards
- 17.5 Challenges of Mobile Journalism
- 17.6 Ethical Issues In Mobile Journalism
 - 17.6.1 Credibility
 - 17.6.2 Fake News
 - 17.6.3 Sensitivity
- 17.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 17.8 References and Further Readings
- 17.9 Answer to Check Your Progress Exercises

17.0 INTRODUCTION

As a student of journalism and mass communication you would have observed that journalists all over the world have adapted themselves to diverse technologies to excel in their profession. New technologies have immensely helped them to upgrade their professional skills and perform better in their vocation.

Mobile technology in general and smartphones in particular have helped them to make their jobs faster and effective. Online editions and mobile applications of newspapers, magazine, radio and television the newest newsgathering device, have evolved and ameliorated their performance over the years. Journalists have also progressed with the efficient support of the 3G and 4G enabled Smartphones. Thus, smartphones have proved to be the real game changer in modern journalism.

Mobile journalism is fast emerging as a new creative trend in the media industry; in fact, it has revolutionised the way news is gathered and disseminated to diverse audiences. Reporters and correspondents are trained to handle their mobile devices to broadcast news content using smartphones, tablets, digital cameras and laptops. Since the emergence of smartphones, news media personnel have become more mobile and independent. 'Pop- up' newsgathering has become the order of the day among media industry; where single reporter can report from his/her beat.

In this Unit, we shall discuss the concept and opportunities of Mobile Journalism also known as 'MoJo' and how it's different from Citizen Journalism. We shall also study the tools and accessories required for MoJo, and the potential professional challenges it poses. We will critically examine how reporters and news organisations are using the fast emerging mobile devices to gather news and disseminate it through diverse media forms.

17.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- define mobile journalism;
- identify the tools needed for shooting, editing and distribution of the content for mobile journalism;
- describe the process of using smartphones for MoJo;
- outline opportunities and challenges of MoJo; and
- critically assess the ethical issues in MoJo.

17.2 WHAT IS MOBILE JOURNALISM?

Mobile Journalism (MoJo) is a form of digital reporting where trained journalists use mobile devices to gather news. A mobile device refers to a Smartphone or a Tablet with iOS or Android operating systems. Reporters use mobile devices as tools to shoot, edit and broadcast the news contents. Media persons have become more mobile and independent in executing their assignments using Smartphones. It is gradually gaining popularity among reporters and news organisations as it helps the organisations to spend less on hiring crew and on expensive equipment.

MoJo is cost-effective as smartphones are more convenient compared to the traditional cameras that are heavy and require additional manpower to operate. Sometimes, it is not possible to send Outside Broadcast Vans (OBV) to cover news-breaks at several spots at the same time. It is during such situations that smartphones come handy for timely coverage of news occurrences. As smartphones are thoroughly equipped with in-built audio- video settings with different MoJo apps, reporters can easily shoot, edit and upload their news contents on the web or to their organisation.

17.2.1 Mobile Journalism and Citizen Journalists

The term 'Citizen Journalist' has become exceedingly popular in recent times. Newsrooms all over India, in fact, the world, have opened their doors for citizens to report civic, social, political and, other reader-interest issues. Citizen Journalism has also helped establish vital links between the government and common people, as they offer suggestions to the government through various media platforms. Since it is not humanly possible for reporters to be present at each and every news location whenever a news event occurs, it is the citizens who send reports of the event using their mobile phones. Television news channels have acknowledged the use of footage sent by citizen journalists in many cases, attributing the source.

From company executives to the rickshaw puller, vegetable vendor, daily- wage labourer, everybody can own a smartphone these days. In fact, owning a

smartphone has now days has empowered the common people with the ability to express more openly than ever before. This increased access to mobile phones has facilitated citizen journalists enormously to perform their job promptly. They can instantly record the news event and upload it to the web outfits, or news media establishments. However, it is important to be responsible before uploading videos and audios as truth and credibility are essential features of objective and ethical journalism and the same is expected from Mobile journalists too. It is also important to verify, check and recheck the facts under coverage before uploading.

17.2.2 Strengths of Mobile Journalism

It is often said that owning a Smartphone is like carrying a portable newsroom. There are several occasions, where breaking news has been flashed using mobile phones and exclusive news stories uploaded on the web from all over the world.

MoJo is gradually becoming popular with journalists, media, and news broadcast organisations because of its various benefits. The work of a journalist has of late, become much easier and faster, thanks to Smartphone. The benefits of mobile journalism are that, it is prompt; helps reporters beat deadlines; and is affordable. Also, smart phones are easier to carry, and trained reporters can broadcast breaking news or events from unlikely locations, where broadcast crew find it hard to reach on time.

MoJos have been able to capture shocking incidents and sights while happening and have drawn international attention. Accidents and disasters happen without warning and in such cases smartphones capture the authentic moments of the story. There are numerous opportunities for mobile journalism where videos can capture some historic moments and the same are instantly transmitted to the web. You may recall videos of people or cattle marooned in floods in different parts of the country or landslides taking places in the hills of Uttarakhand captured on smartphones making way in news bulletins.

Smartphones have made the life of reporters easier as they have become 'mobile' in their work and can work independently without being assisted by a large production crew. It is also cost-effective for media organisations as they do not have to hire additional professionals and instead spend funds on modern equipment for improved production techniques.

Mobile journalists can also go to those places where it's difficult to place camera equipments and hold interviews of people who are uncomfortable to face the production crews. It has been observed that most people are willing to speak in front of smartphone cameras, while they get conscious or nervous in front of professional cameras with large crews. Even from remote places, reporters can use their smartphones to cover news events, without depending on computers or heavy broadcast equipment. The LIVE news-broadcast with the help of a smartphone is generally viewed as authentic coverage, because people trust live reports of news events.

It is important that mobile journalist is first trained on using smartphone for newsgathering, editing and broadcasting, before being sent for field reporting. Once a reporter is trained in MoJo, it becomes convenient to telecast exclusive news from any corner of the world.

Activity 1

Identify some news items in a television news bulletin using smartphones.
Analyse the types and focus of these stories.

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) What is Mobile Journalism?

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) List some strengths of Mobile Journalism?

.....

.....

.....

.....

17.3 TOOLS AND ACCESSORIES

While citizens can record any event; trained reporters are required to handle the smartphone camera for professionally appreciable results. They are expected to follow the process of news selection and collection as well as ethics of journalism. The following are some equipment required for MoJo:

17.3.1 Equipment Required

Smartphones

Any smartphone with iOS and Android with good Internet connectivity can be used for MoJo. These days, smartphones, are available with high quality video and audio features.

Tablets

Tablets are also equipped with high quality audio and video facilities to record, so that the news can be live-streamed easily.

Digital Cameras

Digital cameras, like smartphones are light, convenient, and easy to carry. High quality images and videos can be recorded using digital cameras, which can be later conveniently transferred to the computers and/or laptop for streaming online.

Tripod

For stability, a light tripod is required. A tripod-mount is also needed to support the smartphone.

It is attached to the tripod to move the camera around as you film.

Microphones

A clip-on microphone is useful in capturing audio in an environment where it's noisy and windy.

Video Light

All smartphones come with in-built camera lights, but using an external light is also crucial for better results. However, natural light gives good results while shooting outdoors, compared to artificial lights.

Power-Bank and Extra Batteries

Smartphone batteries do not last long when it is used for shooting videos. Therefore, it is always advisable to carry a power-bank and extra batteries for shooting.

Backpack

A light sturdy backpack is needed to carry all the equipment.

17.3.2 Mobile Applications

Mobile Applications for MoJo are more useful than other audio-video editing applications, which are convenient to learn and use by mobile journalists. In order to master the software, users have to be adequately trained. These apps help in recording, editing and distribution of the news content.

17.3.3 Webcasting

Webcasting is same as the LIVE broadcast of an event with the help of cameras. In webcasting, mobile phone is used to do LIVE coverage of an event with the help of Social media platforms. Facebook, Twitter and YouTube are the popular social platforms where live streaming of videos can be done for news channels and independent reporters. Even mainstream mass media often rely on social media to reach their target audiences.

17.4 PRODUCTION ASPECTS OF MOBILE JOURNALISM

Shooting videos for the purpose of journalism has to be taken seriously and done professionally. Reporters have to follow certain rules while shooting and preparing storyboards, with proper sequencing. There are certain production aspects that every trained journalist need to follow to produce quality news content.

17.4.1 Shots

While shooting for news content, it's important to know the shots and present it professionally. A shot is a single photographed scene taken from continuous filming. It is a single piece of action taken by camera. There are several types of shots:

Extreme Wide: It is also known as the ‘establishing shot’ – to show the viewer the surroundings of the scene being recorded.

Wide: Popularly known as a long shot, it includes a full view of the scene or shows the full body of a person from head to toe.

Mid-shot: A shot framing the person from their head to their knees.

Medium: Medium shots are usually taken during interviews or dialogue sequences. This shot is important to capture the emotion and body language of the participants. This particular shot is aimed at showing the object from head to the waistline.

Medium Close-up: The shot focuses on the face of the subject. It is taken from the head and cuts off around the chest. This shot is also commonly used during interviews with focus on subject and not the surroundings.

Close-up: This shot shows the subject from the head to the neck. The frame is filled with the subjects’ face, while it captures the emotions and expressions.

Extreme Close-up: This shot focuses on a particular part of the subject – such as the eyes. It frames only a part of the face to highlight the emotions during the interview.

Two-shot: This shot is often used in interviews to bring into the frame both the interviewer and interviewee.

Over the Shoulder: The shot is taken from behind a person who is taking the interview of the subject and may also show the interviewer. The shot is commonly cut in between the conversations, alternating the view between the two speakers.

Reverse over the Shoulder: The interviewer’s frame is taken from over the shoulder of the interviewee.

Cut-ways: During interviews, extra shots are taken of the hands and eyes engaged in an activity to create variety and give context to certain points in an interview. Cut-ways can be taken for a maximum of 10 seconds because during edit only 3 or 4 seconds will be used for the content.

Overlay: The shot is taken of different scenes from internal and external locations that support the story. Overlay shots are important during edits.

17.4.2 Sequencing and Storyboards

Sequences are important to support the visual narrative of the content. It is a well-established form of narrating the story with a video. Sequences are formed using different types of shots that we have discussed above.

Storyboards or Filming for Editing Shots: Storyboards are graphic illustrations of stories created before any film shot and are used in filmmaking, documentary making and dramatic films. The drawings are the sequence of shots to make the edit much easier. The series of graphic drawings are also known as filming for edit. It is not possible to create a storyboard for live events, but it’s useful when the story is offline and based on news content. A storyboard will have some of the following information:

Title of the story:

Date:.....

S.No.	Voice-over	Type of shots	Bytes

Those of you who wish to use MoJo professionally should read more in this upcoming area and attend seminars to enhance your skills to become successful professional MoJos.

Activity 2

Prepare a storyboard of a feature of two minutes duration on the implementation of Poshan Abhiyaan in a neighboring area. Before proceeding for the shoot, write a voice over, description of the shots and bytes as explained above.

17.5 CHALLENGES OF MOBILE JOURNALISM

With the advent of 2G, 3G, and 4G technologies in India, mobile companies are producing high-end smart phones at affordable costs. The prices of smart phones are quite competitive and consumers have wide choices to pick and choose the brand of their preference. Let's discuss some of the challenges faced by MoJos.

Several technological, financial and logistical issues may arise while shooting with mobile phones. Some of these are listed below:

Battery Related: The average life of smart phones battery is low, especially while shooting. In order to avoid abrupt disconnection in the mist of important shoots of an event, it is advisable to carry extra batteries and chargers. Solar batteries can be used to prevent such challenges. A power bank can also be helpful in such situations.

Quality of Shots (4K or HD): Mobile Journalists should be familiar with the quality and standard of shots, because whatever the medium of output is, it is highly important to shoot with 4K or high definition cameras. 4K is also known as Ultra HD, its dimensions are 3840 x 2160 pixels. It is called 4K because its pixel size is four times the resolution of HD that has pixel size of 1920 x1080 pixels. While shooting with mobile phones, the format should be set before the shoot commences. While buying mobiles phone, it is important to check for high-resolution camera phones.

Internet Related Issues: In spite of the fourth generation 4G-network connectivity, sometimes due to poor network, journalists have to face problems in broadcasting live news content. While covering a live event or managing live chats, uninterrupted Internet connectivity is very important. If there is no Internet connectivity, it becomes very difficult to execute the job.

Reporting Challenging Situations: MoJos may face uncertain situations. For example, while covering protest demonstrations or riots where police or agitators indulge in violent clashes, police may resort to using water canon to thwart the

agitators. The reporters could become victims of such circumstances in which expensive reporting equipment and smart phones, could get damaged, or even destroyed. In order to safeguard one's equipment and gadgets during such situations it is advisable to cover the smart phone with a waterproof casing. Selfie sticks and mobile tripods should also be taken adequate care of.

Additionally, reporters may not be able to send live feeds to their stations. If there is no connectivity, reporters can look for a place where there is Broadband connection or a Wi-Fi facility. If reporters are not able to send live feeds, they can record the events and send the tapes or the clips at a later stage, when internet connectivity is restored.

Theft of mobile phones: In the event of theft, valuable inputs and news recordings already collected may get lost; therefore, it is always advisable to keep mobile phones safe to avoid theft or loss. The recording should be transferred to Google drive or saved in a pen drive. An extra mobile phone helps during emergency situations.

Quality and Cost of Smart phones: The prices of smart phones are currently very competitive; but the quality of cameras can often be compromised. Smart phones are designed to be user-friendly with diverse inbuilt applications which feature advanced audio-video settings. People can shoot images and videos and share them with the social media subscribers, thereby becoming active social media reporters and citizen journalists. While the common people have the freedom to choose any smart phone, MoJos should not compromise on the quality of cameras. They should survey the market before opting for a brand of smart phone that is equipped with an inbuilt high-resolution camera and supports the apps needed for production and editing.

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) What are the challenges of Mobile Journalism?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) What points should be kept in mind while buying a smartphone for MoJo?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

17.6 ETHICAL ISSUES IN MOBILE JOURNALISM

As discussed in the previous sections, Mobile Journalism has emerged as an integral part of journalism today. Hence, certain professional standards of journalism need to be adhered during the process of gathering and broadcasting new or an opinion piece.

17.6.1 Credibility

Though reporters have the freedom to shoot and film, edit and broadcast news coverage through smartphone, it is absolutely essential that the standards of professional journalism be maintained at all times. Multifarious skills and deep knowledge of regional and national issues for journalists is an essential prerequisite to approach the right source of information, report it accurately and follow the basic rules of news reporting.

Reporters should consider smartphones as just a news-gathering tool and must not forget the basic tenets of news writing. If a mobile journalist does not follow the professional regulations, s/he could be accused of flouting fundamental norms of professional journalism. The Information Technology Act, the Official Secrets Act, laws relating to defamation and contempt of legislature, and contempt of court are some of the most stringent laws, and have to be abided by at any cost. Any infringement of any of these could cause serious damage to the credibility of the news organisation and to the MoJo reporting stories containing any such elements.

17.6.2 Fake News

One of the biggest threats to the news industry today is 'fake news'. The Internet is flooded with information on social media platforms, so it is very important to separate genuine videos from the fake ones. A lot of fake videos go viral and may lead to heinous crimes such as lynching, abduction, rape followed by murders, or suicides. Therefore, the role of a trained MoJo reporter would be to comprehend the credibility of the news content and check, recheck the accuracy of the subject being covered.

MoJo reporters should endeavour to be impartial and fair in their narrative. While covering news stories, they should try to contact as many sources and parties involved as possible. Unauthorised and non-licensed versions of mobile applications should not be used. The credibility of the content is very important therefore, it becomes imperative for trained reporters to use apps with great caution and take due care while shooting and editing the journalistic content.

17.6.3 Sensitivity

MoJos are often compelled to work under tremendous pressures. However, they should not be overwhelmed by the situation around them and unduly dramatise the events, which might deviate from the real situation. While covering serious events, such as rapes, murders, road accidents or other heinous crimes, proper precautions should be taken. Reporters should not reveal the identities of victims of sexual harassment or their relatives. It is always safe to avoid live coverage; and footages not allowed by law should not be shared or uploaded on the web.

Reporters are expected to know how, where and when they should capture videos. Though it is very tempting to push the red button on the mobile phone to capture critical moments and sensitive times, it is better to restrict oneself from transmitting any such information which might pose serious threats to the public and the national security. They should strictly follow the guidelines laid down by the Press Council of India and other regulatory bodies.

Activity 3

Conduct an interview of 2 minutes duration with a public figure of your area, with the help of your mobile phone. Note that, Care needs to be taken so that both the interviewer and interviewee are visible in the frames (Selfie stick of your mobile phone will be helpful in this exercise).

Check Your Progress Exercise 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) Why should Mobile Journalism follow the codes of ethics of journalism?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) What is 'fake news'?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

3) How fake news can be identified?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

17.7 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, you were exposed to different aspects of mobile journalism which is a form of digital reporting, using mobile devices. You have also learned the strengths of MoJo and how it can be optimally utilised to create news content using professional formats and techniques. Some challenges that mobile

journalists face and issues related to the authenticity and credibility of mobile journalism, including its ethical aspects were also explained.

While smartphones enable users to take video shots of whatever is happening around them, it has propelled media experts to understand the complexities of news being circulated without any firm basis and truth. Therefore, certain essential criteria need to be followed by Journalists. In this regard it was emphasised that mobile journalists should consider smartphones as just a tool for gathering news content and take adequate care in reporting. The report should be accurate, unbiased and obtained through ethical means without violating any rules or laws of the land. It is always advisable to contact the authorities concerned for their permission to avoid any legal issues.

17.8 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

Adorna A, 2018, Mobile and Social Media Journalism: A Practical Guide. Sage Publications.

Burum, Ivo & Quinn, Stephen., 2018, Mojo: The Mobile Journalism Handbook, Routledge Publication

Hill Steve & Bradshaw Paul, 2018, Mobile Journalism, Producing news for social and interactive media, Taylor & Francis Publication

Stephens Mitchell, 2018, Beyond News: The future of Journalism, Kindle Edition

Montgomery R, 2014: A Field Guide for Mobile Journalism. Visual Editors

17.9 ANSWER TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS EXERCISES

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

- 1) Mobile Journalism or MoJo is a form of digital reporting in which trained journalists use mobile devices to gather news. A mobile device may be a smartphone, or tablet with iOS or Android operating systems.
- 2) MoJo is gradually gaining popularity among reporters and news organisations as such news contents can be easily shot, edited and broadcast with just one mobile device. The growing popularity of MoJo can be attributed to the use of single mobile device for newsgathering. Smartphones have made the life of reporters much easier as they can work independently without depending on a large production crew. They can also use smartphones to cover news events, without depending on computers or heavy camera equipment. It is also cost-effective for media organisations who need not hire many professionals.

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

- 1) Mobile Journalism has some technical, logistical and financial challenges. The average battery life of smartphones drains fast during video shooting, and the reporter could miss crucial shots while filming if the battery runs out. It is, therefore, advisable to carry extra batteries and chargers. Solar batteries can be used in this regard. At times due to various reasons internet

connectivity may get completely cut-off. In such situations, reporters are not able to send live feeds to their stations.

- 2) Markets are flooded with smartphones of varied qualities and features. While buying a phone for the purpose of MoJo, one should ensure to buy a good quality phone with a high-resolution camera and the device should support apps which may be needed for production and editing.

Check Your Progress Exercise 3

- 3) Mobile Journalism follows the process of gathering news and broadcast content and high standards of journalism. Reporters should consider smartphones as just a tool for gathering news content and follow all ethics of journalism. The report should be accurate, unbiased and obtained through ethical means without violating any rules or laws as per the constitution of India.
- 4) Fake news has become a great menace and threat to the news industry all over the world. Fake news is misinformation and often does not have any credibility or a reliable source. With a huge amount of information available on the Internet, it is difficult to differentiate between the real and fake news. The role of a trained MoJo reporter would be to understand the accuracy of news content and conduct research on the subject to be filmed.
- 5) Fake news can be identified by checking the content and the source from where it is coming and cross checking the information received from other sources.

UNIT 18 COMMUNITY MEDIA AND DEVELOPMENT

Structure

- 18.0 Introduction
- 18.1 Learning Outcomes
- 18.2 Definition and Concept of Community Media
 - 18.2.1 Definition and Concept
 - 18.2.2 Characteristics of Community Media:
 - 18.2.3 Forms of Community Media
- 18.3 Community Media and Development
- 18.4 Community Media in India: Case studies
- 18.5 Engaging Community in Community Media
 - 18.5.1 Steps in Development of Community Media
 - 18.5.2 Participation and Community Media
- 18.6 Challenges in Community Media
- 18.7 Let Us Sum Up
- 18.9 References and Further Readings
- 18.8 Answer to Check Your Progress Exercises

18.0 INTRODUCTION

According to Danial Learner, people's participation in media and literacy can accelerate development (Shah, H.,(2011). Exposure to media as well as participation brings a change in the thinking and general perspective. Wilbur Schramme asserted that exposure to media bridges the divide between the informed and uninformed people. There are several experiments conducted in India as well as internationally to use the media for development, these experiments are done with all types of media forms including technology-based as well not technological like newspapers, television, radio, mobile phone, new media, and information and communication technologies (ICT). It has been proved over the years that the media can play a catalyst in building a better society. Community media uses both technologies as well non-technological tools in various development initiatives. With this premise following are the learning outcomes:

18.1 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After studying this Unit, you should be able to:

- define community media;
- describe the concept of community media;
- classify forms of community media;
- discuss the role of community media in development;
- highlight the distinctive characteristics of community media; and
- analyse community media projects in India.

18.2 DEFINITION AND CONCEPT OF COMMUNITY MEDIA

We will see the definition and concept of community media in this section.

18.2.1 Definition and Concept

The concept of Community can be understood from various perspectives. The community here is discussed as part of communication for a development perspective. The people who live in a particular geographical location is called a community, which can also be bound by the sharing common ethnicity, caste, religion, caste and race. But the concept of community is not only related to the physical community but also online or digital communities that form groups based on common interests and tastes.

The word ‘community’ gives us a sense of a big family. Everyone is associated with a common thread in a community. However, within the communities, members have varied issues and interests. But the community media binds them together by providing a platform to address all their issues.

The community can be of several types. It is divided based on geography. To cite a few examples, they could be a village community, a farming community and a tribal community. The important purpose behind the community media is to take care of the well-being of its community. For instance, the farmers look forward to the shows that disseminate information regarding new schemes, weather news, local happenings and much more.

The word ‘media’ has its root in ‘medium’ meaning and referring to a communication channel. News, information, education and entertainment is spread through communication. The physical form includes newspapers, magazines, and journals while the online forms are television, radio, telephone and the internet. Each one is a medium of communication. When we talk about reaching a very large number of people it is called mass media. While community media refers to an exclusive type of media purely meant for a particular community. This means that the audience reach in this scenario is much less and the service caters to the needs of a special group of people or community.

Community media is a key factor in promoting pluralistic media ecology. Besides, it also works as an alternative to the mainstream and corporate media. From citizens participation point of view, Community media command an important place (Wijayananda Jayaweera, foreword to Buckley, 2011). On the other hand Rennie, E. (2006) defines “Community media is usually run on a not-for-profit basis and provides community members with an opportunity to participate in the production process”. Community media often defines as local media, participatory media, citizen media etc.

Kevin Howley (2006) says that “Community media are popular and strategic interventions into contemporary media culture committed to the democratisation of media structures, forms, and practices” and International Association for Media and Communication Research (IAMCR) describes community media as “The Community Communication and Alternative Media section focuses on media that originates, circulates and resonates from the sphere of civil society. Broadly

defined, this is the field of communication that exists outside of the state and the market (often non-government and non-profit), yet which may interact with both”

18.2.2 Characteristics of Community Media

The following are the characteristics of community media:

1. Community media is characterised by its user-centric approach. Participatory in nature to provide democratic space for all the stakeholders in decision making.
2. Community media enables the audience to be active and its content democratic.
3. It is characterised by its roots nature of existence in the local cultures and traditions.
4. The communication is participatory and every community member can participate in shaping the content.
5. It provides an alternative perspective on issues of the community whereas corporatised media houses provide limited focus.
6. Community media is linguistically sensitive and humane.
7. Storytelling and sharing of personal narratives about issues and concerns is one of the key characteristics
8. The ownership and sustainability is in the hands of the community.

18.2.3 Forms of Community Media

Community media includes a variety of media aimed at community development. Initiatives are community-driven and mixed with alternative forms of media. It facilitates and helps to share the knowledge to ‘conscientize’ its members, which results in motivating the members of the community to take part in community development activities.

Community media is not restricted to technological interventions but also exists in human and non-technological forms. Let us discuss the first examples of the **non-technology based community media forms**. These forms are organic and inclusive.

Theatre

Theatre is one of the older forms, where every community has a collective memory of performing together during festivals and other public events. Ramlila, Nautanki, Band Pather, Veedhi Natakam to mention a few. These forms are flexible and participation is voluntary, generation after generations keep performing for the community. Though there is no formal training, actors from the community learn from their peers. Street theatre is one of the newer forms of mostly urban students and progressive thinking communities in India.

Puppetry

Puppetry is one of the ancient arts of expression and entertainment. Puppetry has widely been used in development communication for sensitising masses on the issues of health, education, gender, environment, and social taboos. Sensitive and intimate issues of the community can be dealt with very effectively with the use of puppetry.

Community Games

Community games are culture-specific and inclusive. Celebration, sharing, relaxing, rapport building are some of the key elements which keep them survive over the years. Games are based on occasion, age and gender. The social activists, change workers improvising the game techniques to design games for development with locally relevant themes. Thus games play a vital role in social change and to tackle issues like depression through mental and physical health.

Grassroot Comics

Comics are funny, witty, satirical and capable of propagating strong messages. Comics simple way to communicate local issues. “They are a communication tool for all citizens that can transcend the barriers of language, literacy, media access and social classes or even castes” (<http://grassrootscomics.net/>). In the villages and areas where literacy is low, these visual mediums are effective in bringing change. In the urban areas through workshops to create a campaign on social issues will bring awareness through creating comics. Sensitive issues like social taboos and menstruation can be tackled with the help of comics. Menstrupedia (<https://menstrupedia.com/>), world comics India (<https://www.worldcomicsindia.com/>) and Priyas shakti (<https://www.priyashakti.com/>) are some of the community comics initiatives in India.

Now let us understand the technology-based community media forms:

Community Radio

Reach of the radio has always been more than any media in India. It is a friendly medium to the public at large without any barriers to literacy. Community radio experiments like ‘Sangham Radio’ run by Dalit women in Pasthanpur, Telangana raised hope to bring cohesion among different castes while using radio for communication among themselves. ‘Namma Dwani’ radio showcased that democratic community participation is possible for their development. The other examples are Radio Mewat, Apno Radio, Jamia Radio etc. The community here can be from rural as well urban places. Educational institutions, non-governmental organisations, not for profit organisations can establish community radio stations.

Community television

The early television experiments in India like Kheda, Satellite Instructional Television Experiment (SITE), Radio Rural forums can be considered as community television, where content is highly localised with the help of local talent. India has a long history of bringing radio, television and now mobile for agriculture and health communication to rural and distant communities.

Participatory Video

The cheaper and portable video recording facilities brought the new initiative to use it for developmental activities. In these initiatives, every participant is a potential producer of content, where participation is the key. Video SEWA was an apt example.

The other project includes the use of mobile phones, Information and communication technologies for development (ICT4D) and social media for Community mobile initiatives.

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) What is community media?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) Give two examples of non-technological community media?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

3) List two examples of technology based community media?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

18.3 COMMUNITY MEDIA AND DEVELOPMENT

The developing nations have a mainstream media outlet when combined with the community media in the country, enhances the process of development. The access and the participation from a particular community determine the credibility of these community media. Other features include ownership, funding and control of the communication system. The basic objective of the community media is to strengthen the marginalised communities so that they can define their development, its pace and its process. They function on democratic principles, work on achieving a social desirable change and usually are not profit-driven. The community people run the entire show. It is a kind of complete control and involvement of the community in the programming from the formulation of the policy of the media and its content production and management.

Whatever the purpose, media assimilation by the community are called community media. ***The International Programme for the Development of Communication (IPDC)***, a UNESCO's initiative, defines community media in these words "community-based media ensure media pluralism, diversity of content, and the representation of a society's different groups and interests. It encourages open

dialogue and transparency of administration at the local level and offers a voice to the voiceless. It can bring in together different communities and cultures; this particularly helps in the integration process and creates a pool of knowledge of various traditions and values". Community media is not only to provide a voice to the voiceless but also should empower through capacity building and sustain the efforts of development. Through which two-way communication can be initiated.

Until recently it was mass media campaigns that were used to support development initiatives but now the approach has changed to a large extent where, along with mass media, extensive tools of community media are used to disseminate the message at the ground level. A typical example can be seen in the field of nutrition, where initially communication was mainly carried out with the help of posters, leaflets etc. However, this was not enough to disseminate the message of holistic nutrition and the Government took the help of community media to persuade communities for adopting a process to change their behaviour.

The government agency along with various development partners implemented the scheme of nutrition throughout the country, using community media such as community radio, locally developed jingles on speakers, setting up of various locally elected governing bodies, street theatre and various traditional games etc. To understand the impact of community media various monitoring tools were adopted and it concluded that community media reaches the community more effectively as compared to mass media campaigns.

The formulation of the message, the process to deliver the message, the channel adopted for transmission of the message etc. is all chosen to keep in mind the social-economic status of the community. Communities' grasp these messages easily and retain them for a longer duration of time. For example, the content delivered to a community through the usage of community radio will be far more effective than any other mainstream media platform. The advocates of community media even believe that through this process the self-development process can be enhanced to a large extent. The advantages of community media are now being widely recognised both by the governments and international agencies of various countries.

October 20th is known as Community Media Day. Founded by Alease Annan in Brooklyn, New York on October 20, 2016, the Community Media Day is an annual event. The day is celebrated to bring awareness to the importance of free speech and make the media accessible for millions of citizens. It is celebrated throughout the world.

Community media's developmental role is beyond any dispute. Scholars across the continent agree that development is the most sought after the call where community media contribute significantly towards development. However, communications alone cannot be effective. It needs massive reforms in the social, political and organisational structure of any given country. The community media is comparatively cheap and swift in reaching rural communities. A top-down approach to community-centric media and development made the communication process organic and inclusive. As a part of community media, the use of both traditional, as well as technology based media, could able to create a synergy and fill the communication gaps between people at the periphery and centre.

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) What is the definition of community media according to UNESCO?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

18.4 COMMUNITY MEDIA IN INDIA: CASE STUDIES

Communication Professor Linda K. Fuller (2007) terms community media as 'media with a mission. Community media says Fuller, is also seen as local alternatives, occupying only fringe positions to mainstream broadcasting. Yet, the community media contribute significantly to the process of development. In addition to playing an essential role in the democratisation movement, they help strengthen the citizenship movement, social struggles, and awareness. Regardless of stimulating local development, community media faces obstacles and difficulties created by national media laws (Stefania Milan, 2009).

Several studies in recent decades recorded the fleeting growth of community media. Studies, for instance, in North America and Western Europe, brings us insights where the Scholars think that increasing worldwide migration patterns resulted in the meteoric rise of community media (Mark Deuze, 2006).

Khabar Lahariya Community Newspaper

In 2002, Nirantar - the NGO, launched a community newspaper *Khabar Lahariya*. Its first publication started from Chitrakoot- one of the poorest 200 districts of India. The eight-member team, who collected, edited and published news, focussed on the marginalised sections of the society, prominently on the issues of Kol tribe, Scheduled Castes and the minority communities. The second edition of Khabar Lahariya, after tasting instant success, was floated in 2006 from Banda district, where it published news in Bundeli dialect aimed to connect with its readers on different and popular themes.

In 2004 Khabar Lahariya embarked upon a remarkable success story with political news. Khabar Lahariya today has spread to Sitamarhi in Mithila region of Bihar and publishes six editions in seven dialects from Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. Khabar Lahariya won the prestigious Laadli Media Award for gender-sensitive reporting and was honoured with the Chameli Devi Women in Journalism Award.

Community TV Delhi Agriculture Television (DATV) project (1967)

Krishi Darshan of Delhi Agriculture Television in 1960s and 70s was one the most watched and successful community TV programmes aimed at sensitising the farmers on agricultural issues, policies and practices. The Government of

India introduced this television instructional program to promote community viewing through community TV sets distributed in 80 villages in Delhi. This method also facilitated discussions among the various community members which otherwise would have been impractical.

Gram Vaani

Aimed to use appropriate technology to build participatory media networks, Gram Vaani works for rural empowerment using information, communication, and technology. Gram Vaani had its germination in IIT Delhi in 2009.

A social tech company, Gram Vaani intends to reverse the flow of information from traditional top-down to bottom-up. Gram Vaani has been able to impact communities with the use of simple technologies and tools. Apart from its presence in Afghanistan, Pakistan, Namibia and South Africa, Gram Vaani has exceeded 2.5 million users spreading across 15 states of the Indian republic.

The journey, so far, and the subsequent outcome has been extremely satisfying. Equipped with technology, its 30 rural radio stations have successfully managed and shared the content over mobiles and the web. This technology-enabled content and information helped in achieving much social awareness and participatory goals.

Mobile for Development:

The mobile phone has been a helpful communication tool. Mobile is one of the portable communication devices with which it can be potentially used for engaging the community in developmental issues. Use of mobile phones for various developmental initiatives like education, women safety, health, agricultural extension and farming are gainfully benefited.

CGNet Swara is a mobile communication project where tribal community members from Chattisgarh record stories, issue and culture-specific information. Through Bluetooth, the voice data is transferred to the local centre where the audio files. Stories reported by locals are first moderated by professional journalists and made available for playback through their website and social media over the phone. Professional journalists review and verify the news report recorded from the field. After approval, reports are then uploaded over the phone for the playback on the website and 'Bultoo Radio' application on mobile. It empowers common people to discuss and broadcast issues of local interest.

Kalanjiam Community Radio

Community Radio is a valuable means to deal with natural disasters. An example of this is Kalanjiam Community Radio in Tamil Nadu. It was established by the DHAN Foundation's Centre for Development Communication after a devastating Tsunami hit the area. This Community Radio aims to provide adequate information to fishers and educate them about weather changes etc. Also, various programs are aimed to prepare them for natural calamities so that the extent of damage is reduced.

Gaon Connection

With the arrival of TV media, the biggest casualty was information flow from rural India. Gaon Connection main objective is to fill this vacuum. Gao connection has brought a significant change in bridging the urban-rural information and

communication gap. With customised content on multiple platforms including digital, audio-video content, and print for the rural citizens, Gaon Connection facilitates to deliver rural audiences. This project is present in Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand and Bihar.

The Cybermohalla Project

Cybermohalla Project, aimed for youth to bring parity among information haves and have-nots. The youth between the ages of 15 to 23 provided facilities to work on various skill-based media training like audio, video and animation. This introduces them to multiple platforms. They develop a database of the content through their work.

Video SEWA

Keeping in mind the importance of information and communication for the poor self-employed women, SEWA intends to extend helping hands for the poor women workers. SEWA offers assistance by promoting contact between self-employed women's organisations, the media, policy planners and other government officials.

Started in 1984, Video SEWA is a platform that provides training to its members. The training aims to strengthen the existing membership, motivate and mobilize them. The video recordings and tapes, since four decades, number in hundreds aimed at training and advocacy. Video SEWA also produces educational programs.

World Comics Network

World Comics Network works on Grassroots Comics started introducing cartoons in media content that engaged in a literacy campaign, social discrimination and other social issues. The use of wall posters is one of the innovative mechanisms to spread information easily at a minimal cost. It started in the mid-nineties, World Comics has the credit of conducting more than 1000 comics' workshops across the globe. Some 50,000 people have been trained over so far. As a communication tool and medium for self-expression, World Comics encourages grassroots comics to voice marginalised groups living in remote and conflict regions. It promotes comics for advocacy, information dissemination, literacy and as a teaching-learning tool.

Radio Mewat

Community Radio experiments in India in India provided useful intervention by localizing the entire process. Sangam Radio, Nammadhwani, Gramvani etc. Campus community radio stations focus different as they mainly cater to the students in an educational institute and the surrounding community. One example is Radio Mewat, which started after the Government of India opening the community radio to NGOs in September 2010. National Award-winning community radio works for parts of society that are voiceless, disadvantaged, and oppressed. Radio Mewat, a vital empowerment tool, has gained prominent attention for its outstanding programmes in national and international media. World organisations UNICEF and UNESCO have also recognised Radio Mewat's main works. When it sought to be an inclusive group, Radio Mewat faced difficulties bringing women to the radio station. Besides working for financial inclusion by helping people to open bank accounts, the Radio Station has been offering free tuition for students of class sixth to tenth.

Check Your Progress Exercise 3

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) Provide examples of community radio stations in India.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) List the advantage of community radio for rural development.

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

18.5 ENGAGING COMMUNITY IN COMMUNITY MEDIA

Collaboration and co-creation are two fundamental approaches to engage the community in community media. In collaborative efforts, participation is the key aspect. Paulo Freire (1996) describes participation as a democratic process, and it is not confined to few people. It is the right of every person in the community. As Carpentier, N., Lie, R., & Servaes, J. (2007) observes that “Community media not only allows but also facilitates the participation of members of the community in both the produced content and the content-producing organisation”. The equal respect of the knowledge is important and inclusive in participatory work.

18.5.1 Steps in the Development of Community Media

Stefania Milan (2009) in the paper “Four Steps to Community Media as a Development Tool” discusses how community media helps in human development. She proposes the following four steps for community media as a developmental tool.

“First, understanding the link between community media and human development, second, reflecting on the specific needs of local community media practitioners, third, learning from other experiences and fourth, elaborating with practitioners a few realistic ideas towards a community-friendly policy environment”

In addition, one must keep in consideration Indian specific issues while developing community media, which includes, caste dynamics, religious harmony, regional, ethnic, linguistic and cultural aspects.

18.5.2 Participation and Community Media

The participatory approach plays an important role in community media. It helps the community members to identify the problems or issues, design interventions and implement them on the ground initiating a dialogue. There are many questions to be considered while applying the participatory techniques to communication in community media. Like what is the focal problem, what kind of messages should be communicated, what is the objective of the change in context to individual and social change, what is the role of the community member in decision making and what are the monitoring and evaluating methods. The Problem tree analysis refers to a method for identifying the root cause of a problem leading to communication entry points to provide solutions to the issues. It is presented visually as a tree, where the trunk represents the main development problem; the roots signify the causes and the branches are its consequences. The field-based participatory exercise in participatory rural communication appraisal poses a problem visually and the analysis is conducted using the knowledge and experience of the community members as facilitators. The approach deconstructs a focal problem by investigating the causes and effects of the problem.

When initiating a community media project, a typology of participation takes place. Stretching the concept, four perceptions can be recognised (Paulo Mefalopulos, 2008). A passive participation in community media takes place when a primary participant or a stakeholder of a development participates by being informed about future happenings and the past. The community members' feedback is very less and non-existent. Participation by consultation in community communication is an active process, in which community members provide answers to the questions posed by the practitioners or the experts during the discussions. Participation by collaboration in community dialogue forms groups of primary community members to contribute in the discussion and study the issues and objectives highlighted in the community media intervention. It comprises horizontal communication methods and capacity building among all community members through collaborative practice. Empowerment, participation takes place when the community members are skilled and trained to initiate the process and actively involved in the inquiry reaching a joint decision making about what should be accomplished and what methods should be used. The control, decision and ownership of the process lies in the hands of the community members. When the focus of the communication is onesided, unintentional but biased, high social hierarchies will make some of the community members passive in participating in the process. It is important to identify and address the reasons for passive participation.

Check Your Progress Exercise 4

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) Discuss the importance of participation in community media?

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) Differentiate between passive vs active participation?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

18.6 CHALLENGES IN COMMUNITY MEDIA

Community media is an engaging part of communities and active in many different formats. Exclusively run by a community, it is all about generating local alternatives to mainstream media. For instance, devising local community newspapers, radio stations, or magazines are some of the best alternatives to mainstream media. It helps in building citizenship and raising social awareness.

In the last couple of decades, India has witnessed many raging debates on the issue of broadcasting autonomy and how the media policy and regulations, which strictly remain under the control of the government, should be made easier for the community. However, despite strict broadcasting laws, India has experienced impressive growth of community media yet it remained inaccessible to large groups of a marginalised population. With liberalisation and opening of the economy in the 1990s, and the subsequent changes in economic policies qualified India to receive the capitals, foreign technology, and satellite television. Nevertheless, with periodic efforts at innovation, India still scrambles for a defined communication strategy to strengthen broadcasting for development.

Community media faces problems at multiple levels across continents. Censorship, unequal licencing practises, and adverse laws are some of them. Low funding, lack of resources and heated competition from private and state broadcasters are other obstacles, although other sites of contention include unequal access to the frequency spectrum and lack of formal recognition. When it comes to effective and sustainable community media projects, there are another set of challenges. In achieving the vision of information societies, these difficulties raise complications. Information society is focused on the spread and acceptance of ICT. Other challenges include ensuring the viability and visibility of ICT programmes and regularly reviewing studies in the global information society (Rao, 2005).

For instance, one of the challenges is the legal framework where community media must comply with their scope, content and management and governance model. On the other hand, certain community radio models register an advantage over others with sheer political connection in the licensing process. Canada is a model state when it comes to comprehensive laws regarding community media. It has four types and subtypes of licenses. Access to all bands is permissible. Canada also offers temporary licenses. It offers different forms of funding including access to public funds.

Already hard-pressed with the challenges of strict licence regulations and other technicalities, most of the community media faces a shortage of adequate funding, expertise and professionalism. Apart from these challenges, lack of vision, weak structures and internal power struggle aggravate the problems.

Check Your Progress Exercise 5

Notes: 1) Use the space below for your answer.

2) Compare your answers with those given at the end of this Unit.

1) List and discuss any two challenges for community media?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

2) Provide possible solutions for the sustainability of community media projects?

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

18.7 LET US SUM UP

Community media is driven by the members of the community. The essence of community media is culturally specific to the audience. It helps in addressing the development concerns and issues. It helps in empowering the community to participate in the process of communication and creating dialogue to address their issues. Though there are different forms of community media the most important is people's participation. The sustainability of community media initiatives is important. As Atton.C (2015) rightly says "Content needs context" means when the content should be created in collaboration with the local which connects the existing socio, cultural and political issues will bring meaningful interventions in the development process.

18.8 REFERENCES AND FURTHER READINGS

Atton, C. (Ed.). 2015. *The Routledge companion to alternative and community media*. Routledge.

Carpentier, N., Lie, R., & Servaes, J. 2007. Multitheoretical approaches to community media: capturing specificity and diversity. In *Community media* (pp. 219-235). Palgrave Macmillan, New York.

Deuze, M. 2006. Ethnic media, community media and participatory culture. *Journalism*.

Fuller, L. K. 2007. Community and media. *The Blackwell Encyclopedia of Sociology*.

- Freire, P. (1996). *Pedagogy of the oppressed* (revised). *New York: Continuum*.
- Howley, K. 2006. *Community media: People, places, and communication technologies*. London: Cambridge University Press.
- Mefalopulos, P. 2008. *Development communication sourcebook: Broadening the boundaries of communication*. The World Bank.
- Milan, S. 2009. Four steps to community media as a development tool. *Development in Practice*.
- Rennie, E. 2006. *Community media: A global introduction*. Rowman & Littlefield Publishers.
- Shah, H. 2011. *The production of modernisation: Daniel Lerner, mass media, and the passing of traditional society*. Temple University Press.
- Siriginidi, Subba Rao. 2005. Bridging digital divide: Efforts in India. *Telematics and Informatics*. 22. 361-375. 10.1016/j.tele.2005.01.007.
- Wijayananda Jayaweera 'Forward' in S Buckley 2011. *Community media: a good practice handbook*, United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organisation (UNESCO), Paris.

18.9 ANSWER TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS EXERCISES

Check Your Progress Exercise 1

- 1) Rennie, E. (2006) defines "Community media is usually run on a not-for-profit basis and provides community members with an opportunity to participate in the production process". Community media often defines as local media, participatory media, citizen media etc.
- 2) Puppetry, comics, street theatre
- 3) Community Radio, Community Television.

Check Your Progress Exercise 2

- 1) "community-based media ensure media pluralism, diversity of content, and the representation of a society's different groups and interests. It encourages open dialogue and transparency of administration at the local level and offers a voice to the voiceless. It has the capacity to bring in together different communities and cultures; this particularly helps in the integration process and creates a pool of knowledge of various traditions and values".

Check Your Progress Exercise 3

- a) Radio Mewat, Sangam Radio, Nammadhwani, Gramvani
- b) Lowering the communication gap
- c) Providing a platform for bringing the local issues
- d) Creating awareness and empowering community members

Check Your Progress Exercise 4

- a) Participation helps the community members to identify the problems or issues, design interventions and implement them on the ground initiating a dialogue.
- b) A passive participation in community media takes place when a primary participant or a stakeholder of a development participates by being informed about future happenings and the past. When the focus of the communication is one-sided, unintentional but biased, high social hierarchies will make some of the community members passive in participating in the process. Participation by consultation in community communication is an active process, in which community members provide answers to the questions posed by the practitioners or the experts during the discussions. Participation by collaboration in community dialogue forms groups of primary community members to contribute in the discussion and study the issues and objectives highlighted in the community media intervention.

Check Your Progress Exercise 5

- 1) Community media faces problems at multiple levels across continents. Censorship, unequal licencing practises, and adverse laws are some of them. Low funding, lack of resources and heated competition from private and state broadcasters are other obstacles, although other sites of contention include unequal access to the frequency spectrum and lack of formal recognition.
- 2) The sustainability of community media initiatives is important. As Atton. C (2015) rightly says “Content needs context” means when the content should be created in collaboration with the local which connects the existing socio, cultural and political issues will bring meaningful interventions in the development process.